



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Monday, 16th March, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 1:13 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 6, *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I hold in my hand the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 13th March, 2026, for correction.

Page 1...17.

[No correction was made to the Votes and Proceedings of Friday, 13th March, 2026.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now, let us turn to the *Official Report* of Monday, 9th March, 2026. Hon Members, this is for your correction. Any correction? Yes, Prof Kingsley Nyarko.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, there is a minor correction on the column numbered 28, the fifth paragraph, where we have it written as, “Mr Frank Annoh-Dompheh: Mr Speaker, a while ago”, the words “a while” should be put together as a word which would read as “awhile” instead. If Table could check that.

Then at the column numbered 29, on the second paragraph which reads:

“Mr Annoh-Dompheh: Mr Speaker, then would you kindly grant him the opportunity to reframe his question there?”

The word “there” at the end of the sentence should rather be replaced with the word “then”. Because, if we keep that “there”, it would not make sense. I suppose it is a typographical error.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, take note. Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafemekpor: Mr Speaker, may I invite you to the column numbered 2, the page numbered 8, on the last paragraph. What I said was that:

“We have allowed you, the Minority, to ask all your supplementary questions. So, allow Mr Speaker to rule on this matter.”

So, if it can be properly recaptured. The last sentence under the paragraph bearing my name should read,

“We have allowed you, the Minority, to ask all your supplementary questions. So, allow Mr Speaker to rule out this matter.”

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do you want the word “Minority” to be inserted?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it was a banter, but that was exactly what I said.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Table, you may take note.

Yes, any further corrections?

Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Monday, 9th March, 2026, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

We now move to Urgent Questions. Yes, Hon Member?

1:23 p.m.

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, just before we go to the Urgent Questions, you may recall that last week we brought to the attention of the House the disturbances in recruitment into security services.

Mr Speaker, over the weekend, our constituents received notices on their phones directing some of them to go for medicals. I would want to plead with the Majority Leader if, as promised by the

Minister for the Interior, the process could be halted while the Minister for the Interior briefs us on this whole exercise. According to the Minister, 506,000 bought forms and 200,000 have qualified for medicals, whereas we have only 5,000 vacancies —

Mr Agbodza — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me listen to the former Whip.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, these are matters for Leadership. I do not understand why he wants to be a *de facto* Leader. We have our Leaders, and he wants to rise on a point of order against a Leader?

Mr Speaker, he should stop this. There are matters for Leaders, no? Hon Member for — what is the name of his constituency? *[Laughter]* What is it? Adaklu.

Mr Speaker, there are matters for Leaders. Yes, because of his behaviour, I have even forgotten about his constituency. He should allow Leaders to do their work. He comes here, and he sits behind, and wants to be what? He should relax. His Leader has what it takes to respond to me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, I believe all Members of the House to a large extent, apart from having equal rights, learn from the Leaders.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, do not go there.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, if a Leader is doing something, and by the rules—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, it is for another Leader to intervene. He is a Backbencher. I told him to stay in Leadership. When they won, I told Hon Kwame Govers Agbodza to stay in Leadership. He said he wanted to go to the ministry. So now his Leaders are here. He should allow them to respond to me.

Mr Speaker, all I am saying is that according to the Minister for the Interior's records, 200,000 applicants have qualified for medicals. Meanwhile, he again disclosed that there are only 5,000 vacancies. My point is that until we iron out these challenges, if we allow all 200,000 to go for medicals, what it means practically is that after paying GH¢ 1,600 each, because the medicals cost GH¢1,600 it means that 200,000 are going for medicals with a legitimate expectation. Yet only 5,000 would qualify.

Mr Speaker, I would not belabour this matter. All I am saying is that since the Minister for the Interior assured this House that he would come and brief us, the whole process should be put on ice until we receive the briefing for some clarity. But for 200,000 people to go and pay GH¢1,600, when we know that only about 5,000 will qualify, will create a huge problem for the unemployed youth who are already desperate. So, it is a humble plea I am making to the Minister for the Interior through the Leader of Government Business to help in

sanitising this space. As it is today, once the medicals starts and they are paying GH¢1,600, the pressure will fall on all MPs.

Mr Speaker, I was in Winneba and I could not contain the pressure on me. I am sure other Members are having the same challenge.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, indeed, there is recruitment going on for entry into the various security agencies and services, and indeed, large numbers of young people, male, female across the country, have put in their application and the process is rigorous.

Mr Speaker, when I was sitting on this Side of the Chamber, I recall, I led several discussions in this Chamber, insisting that any time there is recruitment, every young person must be given a fair opportunity. Every young person must be given a fair opportunity. I recall calling the former Minister for the Interior, Hon Ambrose Derry, here at that time. He indicated that after the first year's advertisement, the numbers they obtained constituted a database. For the rest of his tenure as the Minister for the Interior, that database was what they relied on to give people the opportunity to join the security agencies. We promised every young person in this country that we will give them a fair opportunity. So, what we are doing is simply giving every young person a fair opportunity. We could have gone for our

foot soldiers, listed them and given them the opportunity, the same way that the New Patriotic Party (NPP) did. But we are not doing that. We are not. We are giving every young person an opportunity. Now, if over 500,000 people have applied, it shows the enormity and the problem of unemployment in this country that we need to fix, because all they are doing is looking for a stable job. That is what these young people want. They just want a stable job and to them, a job in the security agencies appears to be a stable job. It will earn them something.

Mr Speaker, I know people who have first and master's degrees, but have stepped down to use their senior high school qualification just so that they can be eligible to apply. I mean, the situation must be desperate for a person with a master's or a first degree, to step down and use their senior high school certificate to apply for a job. Such young people have decided to take their chances. We cannot say that if we allow him or her to go and then pay for medicals, afterwards there will be a problem. If we ask the young person today, if we should allow him or her to go and pay for medicals and get to the last point, or if we should save him or her from paying the medicals, he will hope to be allowed to go and do the medicals and get to the last point, hoping that he or she will be among the 5,000 that will be chosen. That is the dilemma that we are confronted with. Who are we to say that the person should withdraw? I have heard my Friends on the Minority Side mention at press conferences that the Minister for the Interior should refund.

They did the same thing, advertised, people paid, and they never refunded GH¢1.00 to anyone.

Mr Speaker, I have the *Hansard* of this House which is a record of the proceedings of when Hon Ambrose Dery was also brought before this House and asked the same question regarding refunds to the young people. He did not. He reserved the money, at the time, it was about GH¢35 million. It is there. It is in the *Hansard*. So, he cannot be discussing refund now. Let us discuss how we can fix the economy so that jobs can be created for all these young people. If in the last eight years, we were able to absorb 100,000 of them yearly, we would not have had the numbers that we are having now. In the last eight years, if we were absorbing even small numbers—The cost of the proposed national cathedral could have established businesses that would employ many young people. The cathedral, how much money did we spend? All the waste, the moneys that were spent on COVID-19, if we channelled those moneys into finishing the 1 District, 1 Factory (1D1F) Initiative, can we imagine how many jobs would have been created?

1:33 p.m.

If we had spent that money finishing the Agenda 111, can you imagine how many jobs would have been created? There would have been 111 hospitals across the country employing these young people. Can you imagine where we would have been in terms of job creation? If you had finished the Pwalugu Tomato Factory, would we be

where we are? [**Some Hon Members:** No] So please, let us stop what we are doing. We are confronted with a problem. Let us face it as a country and deal with it and we in the National Democratic Congress (NDC) will deal with it. We will face this squarely. We will fix the economy. We will revitalise our private sector so that they will create jobs. Government alone cannot keep increasing its size beyond its capacity. So yes, only 5,000. It could have been 10,000, 20,000, but who is going to pay? Are we going to go again taking loans, getting into huge debts, destroying the value of our cedi, destroying our reputation internationally, having our economy and finances declared junk? We cannot go back to those days. It requires discipline and sacrifice and this is where we are.

So, Minority Leader, as for the Minister coming to brief this House, I have no objection. This is the people's House. Anything concerning the people, the Ministers who work for the people should come and brief the people. We can discuss it but be careful what kind of stand you would want to take because whatever stand you want to take today, we will show you that yesterday, you took the stand which has brought us here today and you had no problem with that. You cannot all of a sudden change position overnight and say that money should be refunded. How can money be refunded? Is that the solution? Is the young man looking for the money? The young man is looking for a job. He wants Government to create a job for him and that is what we must be doing; creating jobs. If you refund the GH¢200 to him,

what is he going to do with it? And why are you more worried about funding people? It is obvious that you are not even concerned about the young people not getting jobs. You are concerned about the idea that they will come to you to ask for money to pay for their medicals. That appears to be your primary concern; that the young people will be coming to you. The young people in Winneba, please do not go to him for money. [*Laughter*] Find your money and go and do your medicals and give yourself a chance to be recruited. [*Laughter*] Find your own money because your Member of Parliament (MP) is not willing to give you money. [*Laughter*] Mr Speaker, I have nothing more to add. [*Laughter*]

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, is this going to be a banter? I thought out of the blue, I gave you the opportunity so I must take him also, so when I give you a right to rebut, will I go back to him?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am not rebutting but I think this is a moment for leaders. Mr Speaker, I have heard Leader but my key concern is founded in concerns by many Members of this House, including the Majority Leader himself. When a system does not offer certainty, it must obviously be reviewed. When a system does not offer clarity, it must certainly be reviewed. But if we would always go back and say, something happened yesterday and it was not good, so we should not talk about it, then what is the

essence of a reset? Their slogan is reset and I am saying that they are now asking 200,000 people to go and pay GH¢1,600 each, when in fact they have only vacancy for 5,000. It means 195,000 people are going to pay GH¢1,600. Multiply that. In the end, the desperate youth will be frustrated. They will come to us for money to go and do medicals that they will never get the opportunity to get recruited. So, Mr Speaker, if the Majority Leader's response to me is that, in fact, something happened during NPP era, so we should shut up, I hear him. But on the issue about the Winneba youth, over the weekend, I have already told them. That is the truth. It is on social media. I told them that the Minister said the applicants are 200,000, so they will waste their money if they pay for the medicals. *[Uproar]* Yes, I have told them. I did. *[Uproar]* I told them. I am saying what is already out there. Do not worry. So, the tutorial from the Majority Leader is nothing new. I told them that if they get a notice to go and do medicals, they should not waste the GH¢1,600 because they will not get a chance. They said they are only going to recruit 5,000. Why do they have to go? If you add that money to the GH¢220, it means that they are going to lose over GH¢1800 excluding their transport. About 500,000 people have already lost opportunity through this so-called Artificial Intelligence (AI) aptitude test. Then another 200,000 are being told to go for medicals, of which only 5,000 will be selected. They are going to waste money. Already they are poor; they do not have money and they are going to borrow. I have told the youth in Winneba that the system is not fair, so they should not go

and borrow money to do medical with the expectation that they will be considered. They will never get a chance, so if they go and pay money, it will be waste. So, Mr Speaker, I have already told them. I do not want to carry the burden.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, kindly conclude.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I would end it. It is a national issue that is affecting their own foot soldiers but if the Majority Leader has this response for me, I have heard him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, an Urgent Question has been scheduled for the Minister for Energy and Green Transition. I will therefore ask the Minister to take the designated seat as I call on Hon Tanko Mustapha Amadu, Member of Parliament for Bia West to pose the Urgent Question. Hon Member, you have the floor.

URGENT QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF ENERGY AND GREEN TRANSITION

Measures Implemented to Address Persistent Power Supply Challenges

Mr Tanko Mustapha Amadu (NDC — Bia West): Most grateful, Mr Speaker. I rise to ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition what specific measures have been implemented to address the persistent power supply challenges in the Bia West Constituency. Thank you.

Minister for Energy and Green Transition (Dr John Abdulai Jinapor) (MP): Mr Speaker, thank you very much. We received a request from Hon Tanko Mustapha Amadu on what he described as persistent power outages in his constituency for a very long time. Indeed, he indicated that this challenge has persisted for some time. Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG) responded to him on the 28th of July, 2025.

The Challenge

The Bia West Constituency in the Western Region is served by a 33kv Bonsu Nkwanta feeder. The length of that feeder to Bia is about 80km and in the power sector, when you have such a long distance and you are supplying power, it becomes difficult. So that is the problem we inherited as a government and let me re-echo that, a 33kv Bonsu Nkwanta feeder of about 80km passing through the forest creates a major challenge. So we have a proposed solution. We want to construct and divert a 6km portion of the Benchema feeder between Nsesemu and Elukrom. This intervention will minimise outages arising from vegetation cover which always affects the line. Also, we intend to completely remove trees along portions of the feeder routes to further reduce interference. This measure would require the active involvement and participation of residents along these sections of the feeder and more especially from the Forestry Commission. We have written to the Forestry Commission to seek approval from them to embark on this exercise. But Mr Speaker, more importantly, a contract was signed with

Messrs Emisa Engineering Works on 19th January, 2026 on my instruction. I insisted that the contract be signed and I can confirm that the contract has been signed to construct a new 6km line to close the gap between Nsesemu on the Bonsu Nkwanta feeder and Elukrom. When this is completed, it will serve as an alternative feeder to the Bia Constituency using the 33kv Benchema feeder which is more reliable and reduce outages in the Bia Constituency ultimately. It will also sectionalise the 33kv Bonsu Nkwanta feeder to primarily serve Bonsu Nkwanta.

Mr Speaker, what we are doing is that instead of taking the power from Bonsu Nkwanta all the way to Bia, we want the Bonsu Nkwanta feeder to feed only Bonsu. Then on completion of this 6km line, we would then dedicate the other feeder to Nkwanta so that you have reliable and stable supply of power. Due to the nature of the vegetation, we have requested assistance from the Bia West District Assembly and I would implore the MP to support us so that together with the Assembly, we can fell 60 trees along that route so that the interference is minimised.

1:43 p.m.

The Assembly on 27th February, 2026, wrote to the Forest Services Division of the Forestry Commission to seek approval for the felling of these trees to pave way for the new line. We are currently in discussion with the Forestry Commission. I have personally taken it up with the Minister for the sector, and so I can assure the Hon

Member of Parliament that the Government is not sleeping. We are working around the clock to deal with this hydra-headed problem we inherited.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Amadu: No, Mr Speaker, except to thank the Minister and His Excellency John Dramani Mahama for coming to our aid.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a constituency-specific Question. The Question even indicates that it is constituency-specific. Leader, on this occasion, please give it to me, as the Question is constituency-specific.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am not going to abuse the special privilege. I just wanted some clarity. The Minister talked about some reforms that were being taken to ensure that electricity is extended to that part of the country.

I just wanted the Minister to be very specific about exactly what the Ministry is doing to ensure that the persistent challenges in power supply are addressed. That was at the heart of the Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is exactly the measures the Minister has enumerated, so that Question has been answered.

Hon Members, the Minister is also scheduled to answer some Oral Questions. So, as he is seated, I call on the Hon Member for Kwadaso, Prof Kingsley Nyarko, to start with the Question numbered 304. You have the floor.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF ENERGY AND GREEN TRANSITION

Processes Initiated to Increase Green Energy Component of the Ministry

Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition what processes the Ministry has initiated to increase the green energy component of the Ministry.

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, we have launched key processes and measures to accelerate the green transition of Ghana's energy sector, as articulated by His Excellency the President. These include the National Energy Transition Framework, a revised Renewable Energy Master Plan, and the new Renewable Energy & Green Transition Directorate, which will drive sector growth and, ultimately, be hived off to form the Renewable Energy Authority as part of our green agenda.

Recognising dwindling external funding, we established the Renewable Energy and Green Transition Fund with approval from the Office of the President to mobilise domestic resources and provide essential financial support. We

are also working on establishing the Renewable Energy Authority to strategically drive the development and growth of the renewable energy sector.

We are implementing programs to boost renewables in the generation mix. Last year, we added approximately 80 MW—mostly solar—bringing total installed capacity to 280 MW. Key ongoing projects include the 200 MW Dawa Solar Project, 100 MW Bui Solar Project, Sunon Asogli 50 MW Solar Project, VRA 30 MW Floating Solar, and a 200 MW solar + 1,000 MWh BESS project we are about to procure.

Mr Speaker, what we are seeking to do is to advertise through competitive processes for 200 megawatts of battery energy storage to be constructed across the country so that at night, when the peak demand is higher, we can inject this power into the sector. These will significantly expand capacity upon completion.

The Ministry is deploying solar in the water and agriculture sectors to enhance access for domestic use and irrigation. Currently, the Ministry is deploying two solar-powered water schemes in the Savannah and Central Regions, and a solar plant to revamp the Dawhenya Irrigation Scheme in Greater Accra. And based on the outcome of that project, this year we intend to roll that project out on a mass scale.

In 2025, the Ministry completed the rehabilitation of the 5 pilot minigrids in Pediatorkope in the Ada East Municipality, Kudorkope in the Krache

East Municipality, Aglakope in the Krache West Municipality, and Atigagome and Wayokope in the Sene East District. The Ministry also completed and commissioned 3 new mini-grids in the Alorkpem, Aflivie and Azizakpe islands in the Ada East Municipality.

To accelerate last-mile electrification, the Ministry is also rolling out renewable-powered mini-grids and solar home systems for islands and lakeside communities, so that communities that cannot be connected to the national grid would also enjoy electricity. Construction is underway on 35 mini grids to serve 47 such communities. To cut energy costs for homes and businesses, the Ministry has launched a Net-Metering program targeting 12,000 installations in secondary schools, district hospitals, homes, and Small to Medium Scale Enterprises (SMEs).

The Ministry has initiated the process to locally manufacture and distribute one million improved cookstoves in partnership with Better Planet, India. Under the World Bank-funded Programme for Results (PforR), the Ministry will distribute LPG cookstoves to households and commercial entities nationwide. Through this integrated policy, institutional, and project measures, the Ministry is steadily increasing the renewable share in Ghana's electricity mix and advancing a sustainable, climate-resilient energy future.

Mr Speaker, this year we will be constructing solar parks where electric-powered cars can charge their cars. We will be coming up with a Legislative

Instrument (L.I.) that will regulate how we set up charging points for electric vehicles, particularly encouraging people to adopt solar when it comes to the charging of electric vehicles.

Mr Speaker, these are but a few of the projects that the Ministry is currently pursuing in furtherance towards our agenda to promote renewable energy consumption in the country.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Prof K. Nyarko: Mr Speaker, let me thank the Hon Minister for doing justice to the topic.

My first supplementary question is how much has been generated by the Renewable Energy and Green Transition Fund?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, this must come by way of a specific question, not to take the Minister by surprise. Your Question is about the measures and processes the Ministry has initiated to increase the green energy component of the Ministry. But your supplementary question is how much has been generated?

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I agree with you, but because he mentioned the Fund, I thought that he had an idea.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Kindly ask another question, if you have.

Prof K. Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Minister the status of the Renewable Energy Authority.

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, we formed a committee to engage in stakeholder consultation. We need to do a broad-based stakeholder consultation. The committee has made significant progress. I expect that this year will be done with a consultation. Then we go to the Cabinet, and from the Cabinet we will come to Parliament for perusal and approval. We do not want to rush into passing the Bill into an Act.

We want to do proper work on it, and I am sure that when we are ready, Mr Speaker, we will come to this House for your approval.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us get it right. Your Question is about the processes the Ministry has initiated to increase the green energy component of the Ministry, and your supplementary question is the status of the Renewable Energy Authority. Let us all abide by the rules.

Prof K. Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with respect, at times, you create the impression as if we do not know what we are doing.

1:53 p.m.

He provided a response that, as part of the measures, the Ministry is establishing a Renewable Energy Authority.

It is part of it. So, if I go further to —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but your Question was to the effect that the processes and he has come to enumerate the processes for you. So, if your Question were to be on the status, he would have prepared the Answer on the status to come and give to you.

I read Order 89 severally that the word is not in relation to the Answer, but it is in relation to the original Question, unless that is changed, supplementary question must be in relation to your original Question.

Prof K. Nyarko: Mr Speaker, we always yield to you for the interpretation of the rules. But we all read the rules and we also have understanding. With all due respect, without suggesting that you are wrong, I think that the question I asked and the response he has given provide further strength to the answer. If we are establishing a renewable energy authority and I go further to ask about its status, there is nothing wrong with that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, maybe we have differences in how we all look at Standing Order 89. The closing phrase is that, but a supplementary question seeking clarification from the answer must relate to the original Question and not introduce a new matter. Now, the status of the Green Transition Authority and the measures that are being put in place to ensure a component of the green transition. Is it the same question?

Prof K. Nyarko: Mr Speaker, the establishment of the Authority is part of the measures.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but you are asking for the status.

Prof K. Nyarko: So, the status would then tell me what the timelines are and he has provided the answer. So, Mr Speaker, there is no need for us to split hairs over this. I think that we need to look into Order 88(7).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Jerry Ahmed, let me hear you.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, I was just trying to talk to my Colleague and respectfully, I would hope that this is trashed out so that if he has any other follow-ups, he could ask, please.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Prof K. Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from my very good Friend, the Minister, when we would see the completion of the key ongoing projects he has outlined in paragraph 3.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister?

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, we expect that by the end of this year, we will see some of them completed. As I speak, the solar irrigation projects are about 40 per cent complete. So, we are making progress.

Prof K. Nyarko: My last question was going to be on status, but because of the obvious response from the Minister, I will not even ask that question.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 670, standing in the name of Hon Emmanuel K. Ntekuni, Member of Parliament for Pru West.

Plans to Expand Electricity Connection in some Communities in Pru West

Mr Emmanuel Kofi Ntekuni (NDC — Pru West): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition the plans of the Ministry to expand electricity connection in the following communities: (i) Prang (ii) Abua (iii) Adjaraja – Beposo (iv) Fawoman (v) Dama-Nkwanta (vi) Abeasi (vii) Komfuorkrom (viii) Zabrama (ix) Yawpare (x) Benim (xi) Cherambo and Kamanpa.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, Prang, Abua, Adjaraja Beposo, Fawoman, Dama-Nkwanta, Abeasi, Komfuorkrom, Zabrama, Yawpare, Benim, Cherambo and Kamanpa communities do not form part of any of the Ministry's electrification project in Pru West Constituency. The communities have been noted and would be considered for subsequent phases of the electrification programme.

But the good news is that the Minister for Finance has agreed that we undertake some special projects.

This House approved four regions to commence with, but we made a strong case that beyond the four regions, we had some special areas that we thought we should consider from the regions that are yet to benefit from the rural electrification projects.

So, Mr Speaker, with your permission, I would engage my Colleague so that we can prioritise these towns and add them to the special projects so we can complete them.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any supplementary questions?

Mr Ntekuni: Mr Speaker, I do not have any supplementary questions. I am impressed with the fact that they will engage me and then we prioritise these towns.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 392, standing in the name of Hon Michael Kwasi Aidoo, Member of Parliament for Oforikrom.

Steps to Investigate Claims of Foreign Trades and to Safeguard the integrity of the Petroleum Supply Chain

Mr Michael Kwasi Aidoo (NPP — Oforikrom): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition what steps have been taken to investigate the claims of foreign trades and political actors manipulating the laycan schedule and how the Ministry

intends to safeguard the integrity of the petroleum supply chain of Ghana.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, to address concerns of interference in laycan scheduling, the Ministry constituted the Petroleum Downstream Sector Reforms Committee. The Committee engaged extensively with stakeholders and upon completion of its work, recommended that the laycan framework be legislated. This recommendation has been incorporated into the ongoing review of the National Petroleum Authority (NPA) Bill.

Furthermore, an approved roadmap of strategic interventions has been adopted to safeguard supply chain integrity. This roadmap establishes an equitable framework for laycan allocation, requiring allocations to undergo structured reviews and approvals, culminating in final approval by the National Energy Security Committee. These measures are intended to insulate the process from undue influence and ensure the integrity of the petroleum products supply chain.

Mr Speaker, on assumption of office, we received an official complaint to the Office of the President from the Chamber of Bulk Oil Distributors, making serious allegations about how the laycan allocation has been manipulated and unfairly handled. The President wrote to me as Minister and I established a committee to investigate it. Following the establishment of the

committee, I constituted a laycan allocation committee with reps from Seaboard Corporation, representatives from the Bulk Oil Storage and Transportation Company Limited (BOST), a representative from the Ministry and two representatives from the National Petroleum Authority (NPA). So, I took it from one individual deciding how the laycans are allocated to a committee with this representation and so far, I can assure you that they have been working very well. It has brought about fairness.

Last week, I had meetings with the stakeholders and they expressed satisfaction with the way the laycans are being handled. But the next step is that we want to legislate this whole laycan allocation process. We have already taken a new NPA Bill, which could not pass in the last Parliament, to the Cabinet and we have made that insertion to legislate and regularise laycan allocation.

So, I am sure that once that comes to this Floor and it is approved, it will even bring much more certainty and clarity to the laycan allocation schedule.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr Aidoo: Mr Speaker, I want to know the specific findings, if any, what the Petroleum Downstream Sector Reform Committee uncovered regarding the alleged manipulation of the laycan schedule and whether the report of the Committee will be made publicly available for scrutiny. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The statistic findings?

Mr Aidoo: Specific findings.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr J. A. Jinapor: One of the key findings was that even after the laycan schedule was published, it was subject to too many frequent changes and interruptions. So, as part of the mandate, I directed that when the laycan is published, nobody can change the laycan schedule unless the Committee seeks express approval from the Minister.

For almost one year now, there has been no need for them to write to me to seek that kind of express approval to change the laycan schedule, which brings about certainty and predictability so that people can plan how to source financing and deliver the laycan.

On the report of the Committee, it was my decision-making, but if this House directs that the report be made available, I will comply with the directive of Parliament. But so far, I think that all the industry players have seen the report and the report speaks for itself.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr Aidoo: No.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. We move to the Question numbered 462, standing in the name of Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong, MP for Kwabre East.

Mr Anthony Mmieh: Mr Speaker, I come under Order 92 of the Standing Orders to seek your leave to withdraw the Question numbered 462 in the name of Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong.

2:03 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Leave accordingly granted. We then move to Question number 463 standing in the name of Mr Anthony Mmieh.

Release of Supplies for the Completion of Electrification Projects in Amansie Central

Mr Anthony Mmieh (NPP — Odotobri): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition when the Ministry will release supplies for the completion of the electrification projects which have come to a standstill since December, 2024 in the following communities in the Amansie Central District: (i) Sabe No. 1 (ii) Sabe No. 2 (iii) Mamfo (iv) Odumfo (v) Adwease No. 1 (vi) Adwease No. 2 (vii) Mile 18 (viii) Amanfo Aniwu (ix) Ntweaso (x) Sundantoa (xi) Aworasa (xii) Aduntia (xiii) Yaw Krakom (xiv) Ntonntom (xv) Apaho.

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, Sabe No. 1, Sabe No. 2, Mamfo, Odumfo, Adwease No.1, Adwease No.2, Mile 18,

Ntweaso (Ntwaso), Sundantoa, Aworasa (Awoaso), Aduntia, Yaw Krakom, Ntontom (Totonmu) and Apaho (Apawo) communities form part of the Ministry's ongoing electrification projects in the Amansie Central District (or what others call Odotobri Constituency).

Some of the Low Voltage (LV) and High Voltage (HV) poles required for the electrification projects in the aforementioned communities have been supplied to site. The balance, being 249 LV poles are yet to be supplied to the project contractor for installation at Sabe No. 1, Sabe No. 2, Mamfo, Odumfo, Adwease No.1, Adwease No.2, Mile 18, Ntweaso (Ntwaso) and Sundantoa communities.

Tontonmu, Apaho (Apawo) and Yaw Krakom communities are located under existing HV network. LV poles for Tontonmu are yet to be supplied whereas part have been supplied to Apawo and Yaw Krakom and the LV network, partly executed. Works at Aworasa (Awoaso) are however yet to commence.

The delays in the execution of the electrification projects in the communities are as a result of shortage of some key materials/equipment including LV poles. The Ministry will complete these electrification projects when we take delivery of the outstanding materials.

The projects are expected to be completed by the end of December, 2026. I would want to assure my good Friend that we expect that before the end

of this year, we will complete these projects based on the schedules that we have.

Mr Speaker, thank you for that opportunity.

Mr Mmieh: Thank you, Hon Minister, for your assurance regarding the completion period of the said projects. I have two supplementary questions.

My first one is, can the Minister be specific and provide this House with timelines as to when the 249 LV poles, together with the accompanying accessories, will be made available for the completion of the project?

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, in accordance with law as passed by this House, we have secured commencement authorisation. We have written to the Public Procurement Authority, but we would want to do it through a competitive process. We are not doing sole sourcing, so it will be very difficult when we are going through such processes to give timelines.
[Interruption]

We are not sole sourcing for this very project. What we intend to do is to open it up. I can assure the Hon Member that once we are through, we will prioritise these communities and get them sorted out. That is why I said that I am very hopeful that before the end of this year, these communities will be connected. In terms of timelines, I can comfortably say that by the end of the year. Thank you very much.

Mr Mmieh: Thank you very much, Hon Minister. Now, Hon Minister, with your assurance that you have just given me, would that be different from the LV poles and accompanying accessories to be supplied to Apaho, Tontonmu and Yaw Krakrom?

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, we intended to do that under the process that I mentioned earlier. But, Mr Speaker, under your leadership and under your guidance and with the relationship we have developed, I would appeal to my Friend, if it suits him, tomorrow, I would like to have a meeting with him and my technical men. Even if we have some few poles, we can prioritise and release them while we go through the other process.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Mmieh: Hon Minister, you shall live long.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Question number 541, standing in the name of Issah Salifu Taylor.

Provision of Additional Transformers to Replace Damaged Units in Tarkwa/Nsuaem

Mr Issah Salifu Taylor (NDC — Tarkwa/Nsuaem): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition when the Ministry will provide additional transformers to Tarkwa Nsuaem to replace the 33 damaged units due to overloaded transformers.

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, the Ministry in conjunction with the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG) acknowledges the existence of transformer overload challenges within the Agona District, which includes the Nsuaem community. These operational issues are primarily driven by evolving customer load patterns and broader economic activity. ECG typically addresses such challenges through the injection of transformers with appropriate ratings to stabilise supply and improve reliability.

While certain communities are experiencing overloads, we wish to clarify that there are currently no damaged transformers awaiting replacement in Nsuaem. The only faulty transformer within the district is located at Nkwanta. Affected customers have been temporarily transferred to adjacent healthy transformers to ensure continued service.

At present, 33kV-rated transformers required to relieve the overloaded units are unavailable.

We also wish to correct the assertion that 33 transformer units are damaged. This claim is inaccurate and does not reflect the current operational status.

Importantly, ECG is currently undergoing a procurement process to acquire and install 33kV transformers to address the overloads.

Mr Speaker, as I alluded earlier, we have about 1,000 transformers across the country experiencing some overloads.

When we inherited Government, the briefing I received indicated that we needed to work on about 1,000 transformers. We have been working on them, and we have made significant progress.

Recently, I announced that by the end of this month, based on the competitive process that ECG is going through, we would go into the second phase of mass scale replacement of these transformers. These are some of the challenges that the Tarkwa/Nsuaem Constituency is experiencing. The main problem there has to do with some transformers that are experiencing overload. While certain communities are experiencing these overloads, I just wish to clarify that the briefing I have indicates that currently, there is no damaged transformer awaiting replacement in Nsuaem. Rather, what we are working on is to replace or add transformers to the current transformers. This time, we are adding much higher capacity transformers so that they can stand the test of time for a long period. The only faulty transformer within the district is located at Nkwanta. Affected customers have been temporarily transferred to adjacent healthy transformers to ensure continued service. That is what we do. When we realise that a transformer is damaged, we transfer the customers onto alternate transformers so that they can continue to enjoy power while to work on the damaged transformer.

At present, 33 kV-rated transformers required to relieve the overloads are being procured. We also wish to assure the Hon Member that once we take

delivery of the transformers, we will prioritise his constituency and collaborate with him to install new, strong and high-capacity transformers to address the challenge.

As I said, ECG is currently undergoing a procurement process to acquire and install these 33 kV transformers.

2:13 p.m.

Mr Speaker, just to add that the current Managing Director (MD) indicated to me that he needed to do an open competitive process to establish the base price. When he establishes the base price through competitive process, subsequently, even if he has to do sole sourcing, there would be a reference point for him to negotiate for better terms. So far, we are making progress on that.

Mr Taylor: Mr Speaker, I am fine. I thank the Hon Minister very much. I will do my best to collaborate with the Ministry to make sure that we do a proper follow-up for my constituents to benefit from.

Connection of Communities in Katanga Island to the National Grid

Mr Nelson Kofi Djabab (NDC — Krachi East): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I beg to ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition when the following communities in the Katanga Islands of the Krachi East Municipality will be connected to the national grid: (i) Ativikope (ii) Tumikope (iii) Pai-old Town (iv) Sikape (v) Atafiam.

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, Tumikope, Pai-Old Town and Atafiam and are not part of any ongoing electrification programme. The Ministry will engage the Member of Parliament for consideration of these communities under subsequent electrification programmes for four regions. I know that Oti Region is part of it, and so we would not have a problem. Volta Region is also part of it. The objective is to achieve universal access towards electrification. So, I can assure him that once these towns have come up, this is the right time, we will take them up and include them in the list.

Meanwhile, the Ministry is implementing the electrification of twenty-five (25) communities in Krachi East including Cement, Binagma 1, Chinikope, Mempeasem, Mepekope, and Antonkope. So, he can be assured that these 25 are ongoing. The other ones that are not part will certainly be captured as part of the ongoing electrification project that we want to roll out.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Djabab: Mr Speaker, I am fine with the Answer provided by the Minister. I am so grateful to him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. This is also constituency-specific.

Completion of Gas Re-bottling Plant in Evalue-Ajomoro-Gwira

Mr Kofi Arko Nokoe (NDC — Evalue-Ajomoro-Gwira): Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity. Mr

Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition when the Gas Re-bottling plant in the Evalue-Ajomoro-Gwira will be completed.

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, the LPG Bottling Plant at Axim in the Ellembele–Ajomoro–Gwira area of the Western Region is an Engineering, Procurement, Construction and Commissioning (EPCC) project being implemented by Rocksure Energy Limited on behalf of Ghana Gas under the national Cylinder Recirculation Model (CRM) programme. The project, valued at US\$24.78 million, was awarded on 19th October, 2021 and construction commenced on 13th July, 2022 with an initial completion target of July 2024. However, on assumption of office, the project had not been completed. An amount of US\$8 million had been expended already with about 20 per cent completion of procurement and site construction works.

I personally invited the Board to enquire from them what was holding the work. Upon assumption of office in 2025, the new Board observed that although a Front-End Engineering Design (FEED) had been undertaken, key market and feasibility studies for LPG sourcing, which is a key requirement for the factory and sales, had not been conducted prior to contract award.

Consequently, the Board initiated a detailed review and audit of the project and commissioned independent market and feasibility studies, expected to be completed by the end of the second

quarter of 2026. These studies when completed will be submitted to the Minister and will guide the Board in determining the remaining scope of work and a realistic timeline for completion before deciding on the project's restart and final completion schedule within the first half of 2026.

Upon receipt of this report, we will then be informed and from an informed point of view, we will make a decision on how to proceed with this project.

Mr Nokoe: First of all, Mr Speaker, for the record, it is not Ellembele but Evalue-Ajomoro-Gwira. I also want to celebrate the Minister for his passion for the transition, especially the use of gas. I visited the site and have seen the investment that has been made so far. With the deterioration that is happening, and with an investment of almost US\$8 million already injected—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, ask the supplementary questions.

Mr Nokoe: Would the Hon Minister be kind enough to give some assurance on the timelines and confirm his commitment to seeing to the completion of this project, to serve the purpose for which it was initiated?

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, he has my assurance.

Mr Nokoe: Mr Speaker, I hold him by his words. The Minister, I know, is a nice gentleman—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Ask the supplementary questions.

Mr Nokoe: We take his assurance.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 653.

Mr John Darko: Mr Speaker, I have a question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: On the constituency-specific Question?

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, with respect, gas cylinder recirculation is a national issue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Please ask the question.

Mr Darko: When the Minister looks at the Answer that was published in the *Order Paper*, there was something in the Answer. I did not hear him read that part. I do not know whether it was omission. It says that:

“As of the end of 2024, approximately US\$8 million had been expended, with progress including 100 per cent completion of site earthworks, 80 per cent completion of detailed engineering, and about 20 per cent completion of procurement and site construction works.”

I want to find out whether this information was brought to the Minister's attention or it was just an oversight when he was reading it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is his Answer, which he read to the House.

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, when I am answering the Questions, sometimes I do not read verbatim. If I intend to read verbatim, I may sound boring. So, I go to the crux of the matter, and that is why I said 20 per cent completion of procurement and site construction works. Because from what he talked about, if we do not do that 100 per cent, we cannot begin to construct.

We need to prepare before we start constructing. So, once I say 20 per cent of construction, it is assumed that the initial work that we need to do, which is 100 per cent, which allows us to construct is done. But if it is the will of the Speaker that I should always read everything verbatim, I will do that.

These are my Answers that I provided to Parliament.

Measures being Implemented to Deal with Shortage of Electricity Metres

Mr Sanja Nanja (NDC — Atebubu/Amantin): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Energy and Green Transition what measures the Ministry is implementing to deal with the shortage of electricity metres in the country.

2:23 p.m.

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, we recognise the critical role of metering in both revenue mobilisation and customer satisfaction. While there are occasional

shortages of prepaid meter stock, adequate postpaid meters are always available as a mitigating measure.

To address this, we are implementing the following:

Bulk Procurement

An adequate number of energy meters were procured last year to address the shortage of meters across various stations. Furthermore, framework agreements are being put in place to ensure a regular supply of meters to prevent the periodic shortage recorded.

Loss Reduction Project (LRP)

ECG is also undertaking the Loss Reduction Project (LRP), which includes the supply and installation of energy meters across its operational areas. The project would address the replacement of obsolete and faulty meters, new service connections, and separate meter requests.

Mr Speaker, when we assumed office, particularly for 2024, even though the ECG Board approved about GH¢3 billion for the award of contracts, more than GH¢9 billion was awarded for contracts, including the supply of meters. Previously, there have been similar awards, so it led to a choke, particularly when I insisted that we should implement the cash waterfall to its letter. It means that the revenue ECG was receiving as a portion of its cash waterfall allocation was not enough. So, some of these meter manufacturing companies that had been given huge

contracts could not meet that demand. We have done a review, and now we have reviewed ECG's money from the initial GH¢300 million to an amount of GH¢360 million per month. Not only have we increased it, but we have now indexed their collection to a percentage of the total collection to give them an incentive to collect more. So, if ECG wants to get more than the GH¢360 million, then they have to work very hard and collect more, because the more they collect, the more they get. But I can assure him that following that intervention, we are beginning to see more meters being released into the system. I can assure those without meters that in the coming weeks, we will have more meters to distribute, except that we want to be strategic and not wasteful. But we are on course, and the meters will be made available.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr Nanja: Mr Speaker, thank you once again, and I thank the Minister for the very elaborate answers that he has given to the Question.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, in the Hon Minister's response on paragraph 2, he said: "An adequate number of energy meters were procured..." I would like to know from him if he knows the net deficit of energy meters in the country? I am talking about the gap. He procured adequate numbers; this tells me that there are some outstanding. And I am asking if he knows the gap.

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, I would appeal to my good Friend that I need to get accurate numbers, because this is a House of records. Once he is asking for numbers when we have about 6 million customers—The numbers keep changing. So, I would plead with him that if I am given time, I will get all those records and ferry them through your office to him.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is for a stated reason that there is a limit to what you can ask by way of supplementary. If the Minister should *ex tempore* provide an answer and it turns out not to be correct, then it means the Minister misled the entire House. So, some of the questions should have been specific Questions for the Minister to prepare and come and answer.

Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, you have the floor.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, just a follow-up. I want to find out from the Minister if the meters that are coming in are the meters that will not be "Usain Bolt" quality, that will be consuming our electricity within the shortest possible time.

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, in accordance with best practice and standards, all meters procured are tested. There is a facility at the Ghana Standards Authority dedicated to meter testing. I can assure Hon Member that these meters are of high quality; they meet the

standard, and they will do the job that they ought to be doing. So, I can assure my Hon Colleague that these meters meet the standards of the Public Utilities Regulatory Commission (PURC); they meet the standards of the Ministry, and they meet the standards of the Energy Commission through the Ghana Standards Authority.

Thank you.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, is it the case that the Minister is unaware of complaints about some of these meters, which are already in circulation, that they consume electricity more than they expected?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, you may ask a specific Question.

Mr Shaib: Very well, Mr Speaker. I thought he was very well-versed, so I wanted to take advantage, but I agree.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity. I want the Minister to give us some great assurance, because people want to enjoy electricity. If meters are not supplied, it comes with illegal connectivity, and we are losing a lot of resources.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Second Deputy Majority Whip, ask your question.

Mr Richard Acheampong: My question is, Minister, when are we expecting to get a full supply of meters in the Greater Accra Region and the Ashanti Region?

Dr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, as I said, this year we have reprioritised ECG's procurement. Mr Speaker, while in 2024, about GH¢9 billion was spent in procurement, largely on cables, this year ECG's budget is GH¢1.8 billion, as compared to about GH¢9.3 billion. Out of that GH¢1.8 billion, we have prioritised two items: transformers and meters. Let me assure my good Friend, like I said, next month, we will start mass-scale rolling out of transformers. Within that same month, we should see a massive injection of new standardised, accurate meters following up. That is how we can also ensure that there is guaranteed revenue for investment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, having exhausted all Questions scheduled for the Minister, I, on your behalf, express our sincere gratitude to the Minister for attending upon the House to respond to those Questions. Minister, thank you for coming. You are hereby discharged.

Hon Members, Question time has ended. We then move to the item numbered 9, Statements. Hon Members, the first Statement on the *Order Paper* is standing in the name of Davis Ansah Opoku, Member of Parliament for Mpraeso, and Dr Abed-Nego A. Lamangin Bandim, Member of Parliament for Bunkpurugu. Is Hon Opoku around?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, he sought permission, so he is not— But I thought it was a joint Statement —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is Hon Abed-Nego around?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we can take the item numbered (b). Hon Atta Issah is around.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Once both are not around, I will ask that the Statement be captured in the *Hansard* in their respective joint names. The item numbered (b) is Hon Issah Atta, Member of Parliament for Sagnarigu. Hon Atta Issah, you have the floor.

STATEMENTS

Strengthening Key Institutions to Drive Ghana's Digital Transformation and Inclusion

Mr Davies Ansah Opoku (NPP — Mpraeso) and Dr Abed-Nego A. Lamangin Bandim (NDC — Bunkpurugu): Mr Speaker, Hon Members of Parliament, I rise to draw the attention of this honourable House to an important matter concerning the future of governance and public service delivery in our country. It is time for Ghana to focus on strengthening and modernising our existing digital institutions so that they can effectively drive and coordinate digital transformation across all state institutions. Mr Speaker, Ghana has made commendable progress. The Ministry of Communications, Digital Technology and Innovations (MOCDTI), its allied agencies, and other relevant organisations have all contributed meaningfully to our digital agenda. Yet, these efforts remain fragmented. Ministries, Departments, and Agencies (MDAs) continue to operate in silos, building

systems that do not integrate or communicate effectively. This has resulted in duplication, inefficiency, and missed opportunities. The challenge before us is to empower and equip our existing institutions to be more conscious, responsive, and proactive in meeting Ghana's digital transformation needs.

Mr Speaker, Dr Abed-Nego Bandim and I (Hon Davis Ansah Opoku) had the privilege of serving as Associate Fellows in the Tech Policy Fellowship, funded by Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ) on behalf of the German Cooperation, and implemented by the University of Ghana School of Law. This initiative provided valuable lessons. Since May, all participants have engaged in intensive onboarding and bootcamps, both virtual and in-person. These sessions deepened our understanding of ICT concepts and Ghana's digital economy, as well as tech policy and global digital trends. We also embarked on a study tour to South Africa, where we engaged leading institutions such as the Council for Scientific and Industrial Research, Research ICT Africa, the University of Pretoria, and the Tshimologong Innovation Hub. The exposure and experiences demonstrated how strong, coordinated institutions, not fragmented structures, can successfully drive digital transformation while ensuring equity and inclusiveness.

Mr Speaker, the lesson for Ghana is clear: our priority must be to strengthen critical institutions such as the National Information Technology Agency (NITA)

and the key departments within the Ministry of Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations, so that they can deliver on their mandates effectively. Parliament has a responsibility to provide legislative backing and effective oversight to ensure these institutions enforce digital standards, promote interoperability, safeguard data, and coordinate national efforts. At the same time, the Government must demonstrate the will, provide consolidated frameworks, sufficient resources, and robust mechanisms to implement and monitor progress. We must also be intentional about integrating gender responsiveness into the digital transformation of our state institutions, policymaking, and processes. This will create supportive and flexible systems for women, women-led businesses, and people with disabilities.

Mr Speaker, if we fail to act, Ghana risks turning digital transformation into a patchwork of isolated projects rather than a coherent national agenda. But if we succeed, we will secure a digital economy that is inclusive, efficient, and resilient, ensuring that no Ghanaian is left behind. Before I take my seat, Mr Speaker, we wish to commend GIZ for conceiving this initiative with stakeholders and for providing both financial and technical support. We also extend our sincere appreciation to the University of Ghana School of Law for its effective implementation.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

[Published by order of Mr Speaker.]

Opportunities for Trade Facilitation within and among African Countries

Mr Issah Atta (NDC — Sagnarigu): Mr Speaker, I rise to make a Statement on the opportunities that exist for trade facilitation within and among African countries, the challenges and weaknesses confronting us, and the way forward in strengthening intra-African trade for the benefit of our people. Mr Speaker, trade remains one of the most powerful engines for sustainable economic growth and development.

2:33 p.m.

In recent years, Africa has taken bold steps towards deepening economic integration, most notably through the establishment of the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), whose Secretariat we are proud to host here in Accra, Ghana. The AfCFTA presents an unprecedented opportunity to create a single market for goods and services, encompassing over 1.4 billion people and a combined GDP exceeding US\$3 trillion. Indeed, if effectively implemented, it will not only boost intra-African trade currently hovering around 15 per cent compared to over 60 per cent in Europe, but also foster industrialisation, job creation and shared prosperity across the continent.

Mr Speaker, permit me to kindly outline some of the opportunities that Ghana in particular, and Africa in general stand to benefit when we deepen trade among ourselves. The opportunities are vast:

- i. Increased market access for Ghanaian and African products;
- ii. Reduced cost and time of doing business through streamlined customs procedures and modernised infrastructure;
- iii. Enhanced competitiveness of African businesses in global value chains; and
- iv. Promotion of regional value addition, ensuring that Africa exports more finished goods rather than raw materials.

However, Mr Speaker, there remain significant challenges and weaknesses that threaten to undermine these opportunities. Key among them are:

- i. Inadequate infrastructure, including poor road network, rail, and port networks, which raise the cost of trade and delay movement of goods;
- ii. Cumbersome customs procedures and non-tariff barriers, which discourage cross-border trade;
- iii. Limited access to trade finance, particularly for small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs);
- iv. Lack of harmonised standards and regulations across member states; and
- v. Low levels of industrialisation, which limit Africa's ability to produce value added goods.

Mr Speaker, to overcome these bottlenecks, Africa must take a collective and coordinated approach. I wish to propose the following way forward:

- i. Deepening policy harmonisation across African states to simplify trade regulations and reduce duplication;
- ii. Massive investment in infrastructure, both physical and digital, to ease connectivity and logistics across borders;
- iii. Strengthening institutions responsible for trade facilitation, including customs, standards authorities, and border agencies;
- iv. Capacity building for SMEs, particularly women and youth entrepreneurs, to enable them to access continental markets;
- v. Leveraging technology and digital trade platforms to ensure transparency, efficiency, and inclusion; and
- vi. Political commitment and accountability at the highest levels to ensure the full and fair implementation of AfCFTA protocols.

Mr Speaker, with what is going on in geopolitical world, that is, the US/Israel/Iran war, it is important for Africa to develop new trade routes for us to take advantage of our trade integration. Ghana, as host of the AfCFTA Secretariat, carries a special

responsibility to champion these reforms. Let us therefore align our national trade policies, infrastructure investments and private sector development strategies with the broader vision of a prosperous, self-reliant Africa that trades more with itself and less in dependent on others.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, trade facilitation is not merely an economic agenda; it is a human agenda. It is about jobs for our youth, dignity for our farmers and artisans, empowerment for our women and hope for millions of Africans seeking a better future. Let us, therefore, seize this moment to strengthen African trade facilitation and make the dream of continental economic integration a living reality.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, in view of the fact that we have 13 Statements to take, how many Members from each Side should comment on each Statement?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we can take one apiece inclusive of Leadership.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: In addition to Leadership? How can one be inclusive of Leadership? Is it in addition to Leadership?

Mr Richard Acheampong: No, if Leadership is not speaking, any Member can contribute. He is not ready to speak.

I know where he is coming from. Today he is tired.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, you asked him a very simple question but he has deviated. Mr Speaker, it is one from each Side. If Leaders want to take it, then they can take it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, before we begin with the comments, you are all reminded of Order 93(5). I am not the timekeeper and once your time is up, your microphone will go off. So now the floor is open. Yes, Hajia Ayamba, you have the floor.

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by my Colleague on trade facilitation, not only in Ghana, but the whole of Africa.

Mr Speaker, the issue of trade has been a long-standing problem, especially when it comes to women. Mr Speaker, in our own country, when our women are going about their businesses, they have a lot of issues on the roads; being stopped and searched here and there by officers who are supposed to know. We have had so many complaints. I do not want to be so direct with the issue of officers requesting money from the poor women who are just running around trying to sell one or two things in order to keep up their families. This is the beginning because these are women who just trade but a little to support themselves.

Mr Speaker, let us take West Africa for instance, before we even go to Africa and for that matter ECOWAS, it is very disheartening when one goes to most of the borders and sees what is being done to people, more specifically and I emphasise again, women, who are trading across borders. There are no proper washrooms and yet women are kept at the borders for not less than three days, sometimes waiting for their goods to be cleared, or whatever they call it, before they are able to continue, which is very bad and devastating.

Mr Speaker, I happened to be in La Cote d'Ivoire where we went on inspections of our borders and to see how businesses were going on and when we went to the Elubo border, it was very bad. I cannot even describe it because the way the women were lying everywhere, sitting anywhere and waiting for their goods to be cleared, as they have said, it was just horrible. At a point and I will say it here without any reservation, I wanted a place to wash down, just a washroom and it was very bad. The officers themselves did not even have a place, not to talk of me. It was very bad.

Mr Speaker, our officers need to be given continuous training to ensure that they allow free flow of businesses. Countries need to engage. If we are referring to ECOWAS, I do not see why we should have those problems.

Mr Speaker, if we take Africa generally, the issue of visas—It is now that we are hearing some countries are coming up and trying to give visa-free entries. How do you do business when

you do not have a visa to cross to other countries where you need certain goods? And if we come to our own country, Ghana, our border points, our airports, up to now—

Mr Speaker, there was an issue and I asked a Question about electricity meters, the meters that are used to connect people to the national grid. The issue came up that we had meters stuck somewhere because taxes or duties had not been paid. I asked the Question, what are you telling me? Government on government, the people need the meters and yet they are stuck somewhere and you are telling me that duties have not paid?

Mr Speaker, there is a whole lot and we need to go back to the drawing board if we think that there are issues that need to be regularised or clarified so that business can take place. Because when you buy local rice or paddy rice and you are transporting it from Pusiga to Accra, someone would stop you on the way and ask you to pay something before you go. You would be surprised to see someone tell you that we have families at home. All these things are leading to a lot of things that demoralise our women, especially the youth.

So, Mr Speaker, I want to support the maker of the Statement and to say we need to take it up as legislators and ensure that the right thing is done.

2:43 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hajia Ayamba, unfortunately your time is up.

Yes, Hon Osei-Adjei?

Nana Osei-Adjei (NPP — New Juaben North): Thank you very much for the opportunity to comment on the brilliant Statement made by my Colleague from Sagnarigu, Mr Atta Issah, on the opportunities for trade facilitation within and among African countries, challenges, weakness and the way forward in relation to African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA).

Mr Speaker, Ghana is privileged to host the AfCFTA headquarters; it is historic. The AfCFTA is bringing Africa together into a single integrated market of over 1.4 billion people. The AfCFTA is not just a trade agreement. We should know that it is a pathway for industrialisation, for value addition, for job creation and economic resilience.

Mr Speaker, we talk about economic resilience, but we have been on this Continent where the COVID-19 Pandemic happened and we saw how fragile Africa's economy was. Thereafter, there was the Russian-Ukraine War and we also saw how fragile the economy was. The only war that is not going to affect our continent is the Israel-Iran war; we do not want to hear that is going to affect our economy. It will not affect our economy because of how far Israel and Iran is from Africa.

Mr Speaker, I am being mindful of Order 93(5). There are a lot of opportunities with AfCFTA. It is an expansion of our inter-trade Africa through tariff reductions. We are also going to develop our regional value

chain, maybe in agro-processing, manufacturing and services.

Mr Speaker, AfCFTA is a good opportunity for Africa because it is going to attract investments and also growth in digital trade through harmonised systems. Yet Africa is not taking advantage of this. As Chinua Achebe said in his book in 1983, what is the Achilles heel of the nation, Nigeria, by extension to Africa? He said in his book that the problem is about leadership.

Mr Speaker, we have about 55 countries in Africa and the total gross domestic product (GDP) of these countries is less than the GDP of Germany and Japan. This is making our economies very weak. Up until now, with AfCFTA in operation, we still do not have a single card for Africans. So capital is not kept in our continent. Most of the cards that we use are either Visa or MasterCard; those are controlled by foreign countries. It is time for Africa to also have at least an Afro card that all of us are going to use to keep capital in our continent.

Mr Speaker, the maker of the Statement also mentions the challenges that we face with our trade. There are a lot of bottlenecks in Africa. Even if you have a business partner in Nigeria or in Niger and you want to go by road to visit your suppliers there—if it is a 10-member committee that is going to Niger, I do not think all of you will go and come back with the same number—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership?

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, let me take this opportunity to commend Mr Atta Issah who has been a very forceful advocate when it comes to issues of trade and finance. AfCFTA is the most consequential economic development in post-independence Africa and we are squandering whatever possibilities or opportunities we have with it.

Mr Speaker, a single market of 1.4 billion people, a combined GDP of US\$3.4 trillion and the potential to boost intra-African exports by 109 per cent. These are not mere statistics and we are not just here to cite them. But this is the mandate that AfCFTA has. If we are able to put our efforts and resources together, intra-trade should be one of the very important things which should benefit from as Africa.

Mr Speaker, secondly, we also need to break away from this colonial trap of raw material extraction. All we are largely known for is supplying raw materials which are sent out of the country. The kind of benefit we are supposed to get from the raw material production, we do not get. Because all we do is that we extract, send them out, and they churn out something that we would rather go and buy.

Mr Speaker, you can buy chocolate here in Ghana and when you get to Schiphol and buy the same size of chocolate, the amount you end up paying — and even the taste of the chocolate—

there is no way one can say that the one in Amsterdam is better than what we produce and consume here. But what is happening? There is this colonial way of thinking that, everything we are getting should come from abroad. When it happens like that, we believe that we are taking it from the right source.

Mr Speaker, somebody produces a certain medication here in Ghana, that medication is often not seen as the best because first of all, it is even being sold very cheaply. There was a conversation yesterday about somebody buying some medication for massage which was GH¢15 and the kind of work the medication did for the person. Initially, the person did not believe that medication could be effective because it was bought in Ghana. It is because we have not departed from that colonial mindset. There is the need for us to have solid industrialisation and a corresponding effect of creating jobs.

Mr Speaker, that is why we need AfCFTA and why we must also believe that the architecture now in place is designed for us to take full advantage of. Let us depart from believing that the colonial master is the best person. The digital trade and FinTech are Africa's fastest growing economic frontiers, yet we are not prepared to take advantage of them.

Mr Speaker, finally, there should be non-tariff barriers which are throttling African trade as surely as any tariff wall. The economic cost of non-tariff barriers equivalent to an import tariff of 18 per cent, rivals the damage done by the

former tariff structures. Tariff liberalisation without non-tariff barriers (NTB) reform is a half measure that delivers half the result.

Mr Speaker, this is the time. The time to depart from the colonial capture. The time has come to ensure that we do just extract and send them away. We should make sure that we extract and make proper use of them, transforming them into refined, finished products.

Mr Speaker, the finishing is always the problem. Someone in Ghana may do something very important and of better quality but the final product ends up in a form that people would not want to buy from the market. So, let us take advantage and encourage the Ghanaian people and Africa as a whole to benefit from the arrangements of AfCFTA.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority?

2:53 p.m.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we would allow Prof Seidu Mahama Alidu to speak.

Prof Seidu Mahama Alidu (NDC — Tamale Central): Mr Speaker, thank you for giving me the opportunity to comment on the Statement made by the Hon Member of Parliament for Sagnarigu on trade facilitation within and among African countries, challenges, weaknesses and the way forward.

Mr Speaker, trade is one of the most important activities that is practised in political economy, simply because we all do not consume all that we produce and we do not produce everything that we consume. So, to be able to make sure that people who consume what they do not produce and produce what they consume are able to get what they want through trade—One of the most important contributing factors to job creation and economic growth is not just the volumes of trade that we are able to have, but whom we trade with. Over the years, I think it has largely been an African country trading with global partners like the United States of America, the European Union (EU) and China and the volumes of money that is accrued from this particular trade always inure to the benefit of the developed economies rather than we the developing economies. So, it is very significant that Hon Atta Issah noted in his Statement that we have to find ways to deepen trade within the continent of Africa. That will have been a remarkable path toward economic growth within the continent. But as he indicated, a lot of challenges still remain and one of them includes our serious colonial ties. Largely, most African countries have colonial ties and it is very imperative from the colonial perspective that they trade largely with their colonial partners.

Mr Speaker, if we look at the Francophone countries, they trade largely with France than they do with other African countries. If we look at mostly Commonwealth countries or former British colonial countries, we largely trade among Britain and the EU

more than we do among ourselves. So largely, the whole concept of the colonial bondage still limits our ability to trade more among ourselves compared to how we trade among them. If we look at the whole concept of a single currency, which becomes very important when we want to trade among ourselves, it has always been the idea that the African continent, largely within the ECOWAS zone, to develop a common currency called Eco, we have not been able to do that because of serious colonial interests. Because largely, if we adopt Eco and trade among ourselves, which would have been very easy and more facilitated, it is going to have a lot of implication on the strength of the CFA, which is largely a common currency among the francophone countries. So, the lack of common currency actually creates a lot of problems in our ability to trade among ourselves as a continent.

Mr Speaker, the other thing has to do with lack of common goods. If we look at the continent of Africa, we largely produce primary consumables, rather than secondary goods, including maybe aircraft, vehicles, and all those things and a lot of money comes from the production of high-value products like aircraft. This is because if we look at the production chain, there are segmented responsibilities that come with it and it creates a lot of job opportunities across the value chain up to the time that the goods are produced, compared to where we just produce local goods and agricultural materials and trade among ourselves. So, we have a common product that we cultivate and trade among ourselves as Africans. So, it is

one of the serious challenges that hinder our ability to trade among ourselves.

Mr Speaker, last but not least is the issue of political will. Once our leaders are committed to the fact that they want to deepen intercontinental trade and remove all the tariffs that hinder it and all the challenges that militate against our ability to trade among ourselves, I think we should be able to do better and be able to grow the continent economically and be able to create more jobs.

Mr Speaker, thank you and I would like to commend the Hon Member for making this very important Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to Statement “C” in the name of Hon Jean-Marie Formadi, Member of Parliament for Biakoye.

Second Deputy Majority Whip (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, the Hon Member is not around.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, I would order the Statement to be published in the *Hansard*.

International Day of Women and Girls in Science

Ms Jean-Marie Formadi (NDC — Biakoye): Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to make this Statement on the celebration of the International Day of Women and Girls in Science.

Mr Speaker, this day was established to highlight the invaluable contributions of women and girls in science, while

addressing the persistent structural inequalities in Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM). It also serves as a call to promote policies, partnerships and resource mobilisation that advance equal participation and leadership for women in scientific careers.

Mr Speaker, the theme for this year “Synergizing AI, Social Science, STEM and Finance: Building Inclusive Futures for Women and Girls” speaks directly to the realities of our time and the future we seek to build. In an age defined by rapid technological advancement and complex global challenges, sustainable development can no longer be pursued in silos. It must be integrated, inclusive and forward-looking.

Mr Speaker, education remains the foundation upon which empowerment is built. It shapes opportunity and determines the trajectory of nations. Sustainable Development Goal 4.3 calls on us to ensure equal access for women and men to affordable and quality education by 2030. Equally important is the creation of learning environments that are safe, inclusive, gender-responsive and accessible to all.

Mr Speaker, Ghana is not without inspiring examples. Within this Hon House, women such as Dr Grace Ayensu-Danquah, Member of Parliament for Essikadu-Ketan, and Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings, Member of Parliament for Klottey Korle, continue to demonstrate excellence and leadership in science and public service.

In academia, distinguished women including Prof (Mrs) Rita Akosua Dickson, Vice-Chancellor of the Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology (KNUST) and Professor of Pharmacy, Prof Effa Kaufman and Arlien Bou-Chedid, President of the Federation of African Engineering Organisations, have demonstrated that women can break stereotypes and redefine leadership in science and engineering.

Mr Speaker, the growing presence and success of girls’ schools in the National Science and Maths Quiz (NMSQ) marks a significant shift from the status quo and represents meaningful progress for our nation. I am inspired by Francisca Lamini of Keta Senior High School, a 2021 NSMQ finalist and the first female contestant to reach the finals in eight years, now pursuing her studies at Harvard Medical School. Her journey is a testament to what Ghanaian girls can achieve when opportunity meets determination.

Mr Speaker, this progress must now be matched with deliberate policy action. I therefore call on Government, through the Ministry of Education, the Ministry of Environment, Science, Technology and Innovation, and relevant agencies, to institutionalise targeted STEM scholarships for girls, particularly those from underserved and rural communities. I further urge the House to support increased budgetary allocations for STEM laboratories in girls’ schools, the expansion of mentorship and internship programmes linking female students to industry and research institutions, and

the promotion of gender-responsive STEM curricula that integrate emerging fields such as artificial intelligence, data science and innovation finance.

Mr Speaker, I also call for the collection and use of gender-disaggregated data to guide policy decisions and measure progress in women's participation in science, technology and innovation. In addition, Public-Private Partnerships must be strengthened to ensure that women and girls are not only trained in STEM fields but are supported to transition into leadership, entrepreneurship and high-impact research roles.

Mr Speaker, this brings us to a clear realisation: the empowerment of women and girls in science is not optional; it is essential to national development. Women and girls must not only participate in scientific progress but must be groomed to become leaders and innovators shaping Ghana's future. A nation that invests in its women invests in progress, and Ghana must continue to lead by example.

To every young girl listening today, remember that your gender is not a limitation but a strength. Dream boldly, pursue excellence in STEM, and know that your aspirations are valid.

To my young ladies in Biakoye, I assure you of my continued dedication to empowering you through education and creating opportunities for you to thrive in STEM.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

[Published by order of Mr Speaker]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now we go to Statement "D", standing in the name of Hon Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings.

Affordable Staff Cafeteria Facilities Within Corporate and Institutional Premises

Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings (NDC — Klottey Korle): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make a Statement on the need for affordable cafeteria facilities within corporate and institutional premises to promote urban order, worker welfare, and social security compliance.

Mr Speaker, I rise to make this Statement as a matter of public urgency and the need for the provision of affordable food services within large corporate and institutional premises, including hospitals, banks, ministries, major private sector establishments, and Parliament as this is becoming more and more relevant.

Mr Speaker, in many of these institutions, we have contract staff and permanent staff who come from different income levels, and there are labourers, cleaners, security personnel, national service personnel, clerical staff, managers, and chief executives. Yet the internal food services available within these establishments are often prized beyond the reach of the lowest paid

workers. As a result, these workers are compelled to seek food from informal vendors operating on roadsides, pavements, and sometimes even in proximity to high security or ceremonial zones. This creates multiple challenges.

First, it undermines the efforts by metropolitan, municipal, and district assemblies to enforce sanitation and decongestion regulations.

Second, it contributes to congestion around critical installations and ceremonial routes, making it difficult to maintain order and security where it is most required. It also exposes the workers to unsafe and unhygienic conditions, which have implications on our public health and productivity at work.

Mr Speaker, we have already witnessed that there are successful models that demonstrate that this challenge can be addressed through deliberate planning. The Rawlings Canteen, located within the Ministry's enclave, which serves workers across several ministries, has long provided accessible and affordable options for a wide range of public servants and other professionals. Food options include *red red*, *fufu*, *banku*, various rice dishes, and even fruits. Similarly, the food courts located within the Opeibea House parking complex, which serves staff from institutions such as the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and other organisations in the area, shows how food vendors can be properly integrated into building infrastructure. In that case, vendors operate within designated spaces

embedded within the facility, and pay a modest monthly fee that contributes to sanitation and maintenance of the food courts. These examples illustrate that when food services are intentionally incorporated into institutional design and priced to be inclusive, the pressure that pushes vendors and workers into unauthorised spaces significantly reduces.

Mr Speaker, I therefore propose that relevant regulatory authorities, including the Ministry of Works and Housing, the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, and our Metropolitan, Municipal, and District Assemblies, consider developing guidelines that encourage and, where appropriate, require large institutions, corporate entities, and public facilities to incorporate affordable cafeteria or food court services within their premises. Such facilities should be designed to cater to all categories of workers, regardless of income level, and should be integrated into planning approvals for major developments.

Mr Speaker, by embedding affordable food services into institutional environments, we can improve worker welfare, support orderly urban planning management, and strengthen compliance with local regulations. It is a practical, preventive solution that benefits both institutions and the broader public. I respectfully urge all of us to work toward policy and planning frameworks and stakeholder engagements that reflect this reality.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Statement has been ably made. The floor is now open for comments.

Well, Minority Leadership?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: I was hoping some of my Colleagues would comment because this is a very important Statement. Except that, I just was able to pull one from the console which is not very legible but I listened attentively and I realised that there were three major issues that she espoused.

3:03 p.m.

The first is food security and welfare. Basically, having a clean environment and having a particular centralised cafeteria for workers, and she actually referred to the Rawlings Canteen. I am sure she is taking up from where her father left off, propagating welfare of the workers, and also ensuring that they get all these foods at cheaper rates in a very sanitised environment and the issues of hygiene, which is also very critical in this conversation. This is because if anyone has worked around any of these central areas where we have most of the Ministries, one would realise that the sale of foods is scattered all over the place. We do not even know if they go through some requirements or conditionalities, as in health officials going to check the food they are selling or to check if where they are buying the foodstuff from are proper. Also, how much these foods are sold for. There is something that she may not have adverted her mind to, the issue of time.

Because normally, when they even have the time to eat, they are perhaps given an hour break and if one may have to go to Osu, which is still part of the Member's constituency, to wait for an order from Papaye Restaurant or any other food joint, one may end up spending all the time. And the time that one is even expected to go and eat and come back, one would have succeeded doing other things rather than just waiting to eat. Because the time the food would be ready, that would be the time the person may have to rush and come back, so people end up not even eating healthy. Apart from that, they do not get to buy the food at a cheaper cost. But if we are able to centralise these canteens or cafeterias and ensure that everything is sanitised, those who are even serving are properly dressed and the foodstuff that are bought before they are cooked are all in the right manner before served to our workers within this centralised unit, I think that would inure to the benefit of productivity, staff now buying at a cheaper rate, and the health of the staff or the person buying.

Mr Speaker, so let me take this opportunity to commend the maker of the Statement that at least she is thinking of still propagating some of the very good deeds her father left off and to ensure that people buy food at cheaper rates and get very healthy food to eat. The issues of productivity is also very much espoused. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority?

Second Deputy Majority Whip (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity. Mr Speaker— *[Interruption]*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Would you yield?

Mr Richard Achemapong: No, this is the time for Leadership. She did not come at the right time, so we have more Statements that she can contribute to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, let me commend the maker of the Statement.

[Pause]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, go ahead.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we all know that per our Standing Orders, admissibility is in the hands of Mr Speaker, so you admitted this Statement. Let us start from home since charity begins at home. In Parliament, at Job 600, we have a cafeteria but it has not been operating for more than 10 years now, so what are we talking about here? Members will sit here and sometimes do extended Sittings and we have to order food from outside. Everything now has become politics. Who should operate it? Is it NPP or NDC? And even obesity has been described as part of our sickness. We will sit here and cannot find food to eat. As Hon Shaib was saying, one walks to a

cafeteria, orders a food of their choice, and it is prepared for them. Why do we put up this edifice and we do not engage somebody—We are ready to pay for it. It will not be for free because I am not thinking about the cost. *[Interruption]* No, it is about our health. I travelled with the Hon Member recently —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, you have to make full disclosures about your travel. *[Laughter]* Once you are bringing it to my notice, you will make full disclosure.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Oh, yes, Mr Speaker, I will do that. *[Laughter]* So, Mr Speaker, let us try to think about our welfare. We will be here and hear that a former or sitting MP is dead, then we come here to read tribute among others and say “may their souls rest in peace”. Which peace? *[Laughter]* We suffocated the person. We did not treat the person well. We did not create the enabling environment for the person to operate. As we are here now on a Monday like this, go to the coffee shop and see if one can get even ice water to buy and we are here trying to polish it as if it is normal. It is not normal. *[Hear! Hear!]* Elevators are not working. Air conditioners are not working. Members are sitting in this severe heat and we want them to come to work from Monday to Friday. Hon Members cannot go on demonstration and we cannot complain. We have to work for 48 months before our salaries are determined and when the public hears of it, they say that MPs are taking *ex-gratia* and they go mad. Which institution will engage somebody and the person will work for 48 months before

his or her salary is determined? I was the Operations Manager for a bank. As soon as we are engaged, our salaries are determined as well as clothing allowance, Christmas bonuses among others. Every two weeks, we are paid because they do not want us to steal their money. So, resources are always available before us. Common Fund arrears, Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) arrears —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: And you left it to come to Parliament?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I did not know the situation. *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: For that one, I agree with you. You will never know until you get here.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, the time has come for us to fix it. Let us rectify the situation because all is not well. So, Hon Member, I thank you very much for bringing up this issue. It is not about other institutions. All of us are inclusive. She cannot talk, but we will speak for her. *[Hear! Hear!]* Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That brings us to the end of that Statement. We now move to Statement numbered (e), standing in the name of Hon Vincent Assafuah, Member of Parliament for Old Tafo.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, as discussed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, so we ask that the Statement be published in the *Hansard*.

Maintenance Culture of Stadia and Sporting Infrastructure in Ghana

Vincent Ekow Assafuah (NPP — Old Tafo): Mr Speaker, I rise to address this honourable House on the critical issue of the maintenance culture of stadia and sporting infrastructure across Ghana, an issue that speaks directly to asset protection, public safety, international credibility, and value for money.

Mr Speaker, successive governments have invested heavily in the construction and rehabilitation of national and regional stadia, including the Accra Sports Stadium, Baba Yara Sports Stadium, Cape Coast Sports Stadium, Tamale Sports Stadium, and other community facilities. These investments were justified on the basis of national pride, sports development, youth empowerment, tourism, and Ghana's aspiration to host international sporting and entertainment events.

However, Mr Speaker, it is increasingly evident that while we have demonstrated capacity in construction, we have consistently failed in sustaining these assets through structured and professional maintenance systems.

Weak Maintenance Culture and Systemic Gaps

Mr Speaker, the maintenance challenge is not merely financial; it is systemic. There is a clear absence of:

- Routine and preventive maintenance schedules;
- Periodic structural and technical audits;
- Professional facility management regimes;
- Clear lines of responsibility and accountability;
- Performance benchmarks tied to international standards.

As a result, maintenance is often reactive rather than preventive, driven by crises, international embarrassment, or last-minute inspections instead of long-term planning.

International Standard and Compliance Risks

Mr Speaker, modern stadia must comply with strict requirements set by international governing bodies such as Confederation of African Football (CAF) and FIFA. These standards cover pitch quality and irrigation, drainage systems, floodlighting, seating capacity and safety, roofing, media and broadcast facilities, medical and emergency response infrastructure, accessibility for persons with disability, crowd control systems, and security installations.

When these standards are not maintained, Ghana faces serious consequences including:

- Suspension or downgrading of stadia;

- Relocation of international matches;
- Loss of hosting rights;
- Reputational damage to our sports administration;
- Reduced confidence from sponsors and investors.

Mr Speaker, international standard is not achieved at commissioning alone; it must be preserved through consistent maintenance. A stadium that fails inspection due to neglect is a symbol of institutional failure, not resource constraint.

Public Safety and Risk Exposure

Mr Speaker, poor maintenance also poses significant safety risks. Deteriorating stands, faulty electrical systems, poor lighting, damaged turf, and inadequate emergency facilities expose spectators, athletes, officials, and workers to avoidable dangers. Parliament cannot overlook the potential legal, financial, and human consequences of preventable infrastructure failures.

Economic, Social, and Developmental Costs

Mr Speaker, neglected stadia represent lost economic opportunities. Properly maintained stadia can generate revenue through sports tourism, concerts, conferences, community events, and commercial partnerships. When facilities are closed or downgraded, jobs are lost, local economies suffer, and youth development pathways are disrupted.

Financing and Policy Proposal

Mr Speaker, to address these challenges sustainably, I propose a structured and protected financing solution. As this House considers the establishment and operationalisation of a Sports Fund, it is imperative that a minimum of 10 per cent of the Sports Fund be ring-fenced solely for routine maintenance, safety compliance, and technical upgrading of all national stadia.

This allocation must be:

- Predictable and non-discretionary;
- Protected from political interference;
- Tied to approved maintenance plans and audits;
- Subject to annual reporting to Parliament.

Such a policy will reduce emergency rehabilitation costs, extend asset lifespan, and ensure continuous compliance with international standards.

Institutional and Governance Reforms

Mr Speaker, funding alone is insufficient without governance reform. I therefore call for:

- The establishment of professional stadia and facilities management units;
- Mandatory annual technical, safety, and compliance audits;

- Clear separation between political oversight and technical management;
- Performance contracts for facility managers;
- Exploration of public-private partnerships and concession models to enhance efficiency.

Conclusion

Mr Speaker, a nation that builds but fails to maintain only postpones decay and multiplies future costs. If we are serious about sports excellence, youth development, public safety, and value for money, then maintenance must be elevated to a core national policy priority.

I urge this honourable House to act decisively to institutionalise a strong maintenance culture that preserves the international standard of our stadia and safeguards the investments made with the hard-earned resources of the Ghanaian people. I thank you, Mr Speaker.

[Published by order of Mr Speaker.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then we move to (f), standing in the name of Hon Gizella Tetteh-Agbotui, Member of Parliament for Awutu Senya West. Well, we also ask that that Statement be published in the *Hansard*.

Brutality Meted Out to Ostech Students during Interschool Sports Festival

Mrs Gizella Akushika Tetteh-Agbotui (NDC — Awutu Senya West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this Statement on the floor of this august House.

Mr Speaker, on Saturday, 21st February, 2026, while undertaking my regular constituency engagements, I came across a disturbing video circulating on social media which showed students brutally assaulting a colleague student. Upon reviewing the video more carefully, I noticed that the assaulted student was in the uniform of Obrachire Senior High Technical School (OSTECH), one of the oldest senior high schools in my constituency, with a student population of 1,795 and under the double track system. This is a school which my late father, Dr. E.A.Tetteh, benevolently donated a parcel of land for its establishment in his hometown, Obrachire.

Mr Speaker, I immediately contacted my colleague Member of Parliament for Agona West, Hon Ernestina Dangbe as the incident occurred in a school in her constituency; the Swedru School of Business (SWESBU) and also placed a call to the Headmistress of OSTECH to gain further insight into the unfortunate incident, which resulted in four students sustaining severe injuries and being hospitalised.

Mr Speaker, according to accounts gathered, there has been a longstanding

rivalry between OSTECH and SWESBU. Historically, this rivalry has manifested during zonal sporting activities, particularly athletics competitions. However, on this occasion, matters escalated beyond acceptable limits.

Mr Speaker, the school authorities report that OSTECH participated in a Zonal Inter-School Athletics Competition hosted by SWESBUS on 19th and 20th February, 2026. During the event, a clash ensued between students of Swedru School of Business (the host) and Obrachire Senior High/Technical School.

Mr Speaker, students from OSTECH had gathered near a dormitory block close to the sports field when, in what began as rivalry, some SWESBUS students allegedly started throwing stones from the upper floor of the dormitory block into the OSTECH crowd. In the process, Shadrach Appiah, a second-year OSTECH student, was struck by a stone and fell unconscious. He was rushed to the Swedru Municipal Hospital, where he was resuscitated from a critical state. Fortunately, no fatality was recorded. Mr Speaker, it is further alleged that students from some neighboring schools in Swedru joined in pursuing OSTECH students out of the host school, resulting in individual attacks on vulnerable and innocent students. Nathaniel Mireku (2T3B), the student seen in the viral video, was among those attacked. Mr Speaker, other OSTECH students who sustained varying degrees of injuries include:

- Akpaka Kobi Fiadzigbe (2T1) – Eye injury;

- Joshua Quartey (2V1) – Minor head injury;
- Emmanuel Mensah (2T3B) – Minor head injury; and
- Raymond Asare (2T3A) – Hip injury.

These students are currently assisting school management and the Police in investigations and I am taking full responsibility for their further medical examinations at the Winneba Trauma Hospital.

Mr Speaker, I have formally reported the matter to the Director-General of the Ghana Education Service, to intervene which he has done so. Engagements with the Hon Ministers for Sports and Recreation and Education have taken place. The head of the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) of the Ghana Police service has visited both schools. I also visited OSTECH yesterday to meet the staff and students and assure them of all support needed from various institutions and relevant stakeholders to ensure that:

- A full and impartial investigation is conducted;
- Individuals found culpable are held accountable in accordance with the law;
- Adequate support, including counselling and protection, is provided to the affected students and student body at large for both schools;

- Adequate security protection for all schools' sports festivals.

Mr Speaker, I wish to state unequivocally that I strongly condemn any form of violence, abuse, or inhumane treatment against students — not because they are from my hometown or constituency — but because such actions are unacceptable, unlawful, heartless, wicked and contrary to the values of dignity, respect, and protection that must guide our treatment of young people. Mr Speaker, my concern is on reprisal attacks and other videos on social media with subtle threats and undertones. We have assured parents and guardians of the safety of their wards and will continue to do so.

Mr Speaker, I further call on the school community and all my constituents to remain calm and allow due process to take its course. As the Member of Parliament for Awutu Senya West Constituency, I remain fully committed to safeguarding the rights and well-being of all students and to ensuring that such regrettable incidents are not repeated in any institution within our jurisdiction.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this Statement.

[Published by order of Mr Speaker.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then we go to (g), standing in the name of Hon Desmond De-Graft Paitoo.

World Wildlife Day, 2026

Mr Desmong De-Graft Paitoo (NDC — Gomoa East): Mr Speaker, I rise to make a Statement on World Wildlife Day, 2026. Mr Speaker, I am deeply honoured to speak today in celebration of World Wildlife Day, 2026, a day established by the global community to acknowledge the incredible diversity of our planet's wildlife and to reaffirm our collective commitment to conservation and sustainable resource management. This significant occasion serves as a reminder that wildlife is not only a source of national pride and ecological stability, but also a crucial factor in economic growth, cultural heritage and the livelihoods of communities.

3:13 p.m.

Mr Paitoo: Mr Speaker, this year's celebration is themed: "Medicinal and Aromatic Plants, Conserving Health, Heritage and Livelihoods". It is both timely and relevant, especially for Ghana, where biodiversity is deeply connected to our healthcare, cultural heritage and economy. Medicinal products remain vital in primary healthcare, particularly in rural and underserved areas and worldwide. Up to 95 per cent of people in developing countries depend on traditional product-based medicines.

Mr Speaker, it is encouraging to see that our country has renewed its dedication to environmental sustainability and wildlife conservation through policy reforms and strategic actions. Although

these efforts are laudable, significant challenges remain. The ongoing decline in biodiversity threatens food security, public health and economic stability. Safeguarding medicinal and aromatic plants is especially crucial, as their loss would impact the ecosystem and diminish traditional knowledge passed down through generations. Therefore, it is essential for us as lawmakers to continue supporting policies that strengthen institutional capacity to enforce conservation efforts, provide sustainable livelihood options for communities near protected areas, promote research, innovation and value addition in herbal medicine, improve public education and awareness on environmental stewardship.

This year, as we celebrate World Wildlife Day, we are reminded that our current decisions will shape the environmental legacy for future generations. It is our responsibility to protect Ghana's natural heritage for our children and grandchildren and to promote development that is in harmony with nature.

Mr Speaker, in summary, I urge all stakeholders, government agencies, traditional authorities, civil society, private sector and citizens to collaborate in protecting wildlife, conserving medicinal plants and promoting sustainable environmental practices. These collective efforts will help preserve biodiversity, secure livelihoods, build resilience and support national development. May this occasion motivate us to renew our commitment and take decisive steps to safeguard our nation's natural resources.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon John Darko?.

Mr John Darko (NPP—Suame): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement ably made by my Colleague, Hon Desmond De-Graft Paitoo.

Mr Speaker, the Statement is indeed timely, looking at the celebration of World Wildlife Day. If we look at the theme for the celebration as quoted by my brother, it is “Medicinal and Aromatic Plants, Conserving Health, Heritage and Livelihoods”. This is indeed what we are missing in this country. We seem to forget that the medicine that we need to cure the various diseases that are bothering us are from the plants that we are destroying.

Mr Speaker, the statistics show that 25 to 80 per cent of our forests were destroyed in the last 20 to 30 years. As a country, we are happily destroying the forest cover. We are happily destroying the sources of medicine for the various diseases and ailments that are bothering us as a country. And it is not as if we do not know why we are losing our forest cover. Of course, there are other reasons, like agriculture, but one of the major ones that, as a country, we have failed to address is the issue of illegal mining. *Galamsey* has become the most dangerous source of depletion of our forest cover, and we seem not to care.

Mr Speaker, in the past few weeks, I have had the opportunity to travel with some of the Committees of Parliament to

visit some of the mining sites. And if we see the effects of *galamsey*—Today, it is just medicinal and aromatic plants we are talking about. So, we may not even talk about the destruction of the water bodies. But the destruction of our forests and the fact that, in some cases, Governments seem to be enjoying the profit of this destruction— When we quote the benefits of gold, we talk about the fact that 53 per cent of our gold exports are from small-scale mining. When the report shows that 70 to 80 per cent of small-scale mining engage in illegal mining activity, yet we celebrate this. While we are celebrating the export of our gold from small-scale mining, we are celebrating the destruction of our forest cover and the source of medicine in this country.

Mr Speaker, I am happy my Colleague on the other Side has brought this up. It is indeed timely. And it means that our Government, if we want to protect our plants, must, as a matter of urgency, take on the fight against *galamsey* as a fight that must never be lost because we have become a country of talkers and no-doers. This is the time. If my Brother wants our plants to be protected, then one of the major sources of the destruction is *galamsey* and all of us must come together to help the Government fight it. Let us stop celebrating the export of gold from our small-scale mining, especially when we know, as a matter of fact, that 70 to 80 per cent of what we are exporting is coming from illegal mining.

And, Mr Speaker, on that, I thank you for the opportunity and I thank my Brother for this able Statement that he made.

Second Deputy Majority Whip (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to add my voice to the Statement made by our Hon Colleague.

Mr Speaker, we owe it as a duty to protect our river bodies and our forest cover and it should not be like a talk show. In Bia East, where I am a Member of Parliament, there is no single illegal mining activity going on. Why? Because I am not interested. When they start, it will be difficult to stop them because there is money. When people get to know that there is money in this adventure, if one tries to stop, they will kill them. So, we try to protect it before they get into it. But if we go to these communities in the Ashanti Region, Agroyesum and Manso Nkwanta and look at the gold mining activities that they are doing over there. If we look at their infrastructural development and road network, they do not have a single tarred road but they have all the mineral deposits. They are mining and getting money but nobody is developing the area.

Mr Speaker, can you believe that one will spend between US\$800 or US\$1,000 to mine an ounce of gold? And now, we are selling between US\$2,000 to over US\$5,000. US\$800 to mine an ounce of gold. So, who is making the profits here? Look at our streets and the environment. So, as a nation, can we sit back and think about how to develop our nation? I do not want to mention names. We have two mines, one in Ahafo and the other in Sunyani. They invested US\$3 billion.

3:23 p.m.

So, are we saying that as a state, we cannot raise US\$3 billion to mine our own resources? Spending US\$800 to mine an ounce of gold to sell at US\$5,000; that is the minimum. Let us even say it is US\$2,000, we would be making a profit of US\$3,000; we need to think again as a nation.

Illegal chainsaw operations and I cannot say whether it is legal or illegal because they do markings and are told which trees to fell or not, but when they enter the forest, they do whatever they want to do. The forest guard because of this *no ko fio* thing —

So, we have the fine laws but who are the people supposed to make sure those laws are implemented? We sit here as politicians, always trying to attack each other but at the end of the day, the operators are there. They are taking the benefits and giving us the bad names.

So, Hon Colleagues, let us think again. Let us come together and make sure we protect our forest cover and our river bodies. So, at the end of the day, we can say that posterity will come to inherit something that we left for them, or else they will come and blame all of us. We go to the cemetery and see an epitaph, which says, “This foolish MP, this foolish Minister”. Yes, because we did not protect the environment for them.

So, please, let us come together. It is not about the National Democratic Congress (NDC) or the New Patriotic Party (NPP). Let us stop *galamsey*. In

the Ashanti Region, we know that is what people live on, but we come here, and we say “it is government”. As MP or as Ministers, what are we doing? For me, I have stopped *galamsey* in my constituency. So, you should stop *galamsey* in your constituency.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that brings us to the end of comments on that Statement. The next person in line is Hon Abla Gomashie. Since she is not here, I will direct that her Statement be published in the Hansard.

Commemoration of International Mother Language Day

Minister for Culture, Tourism and Creative Arts (Ms Abla Dzifa Gomashie) (MP): Mr Speaker, Hon Members, Saturday, 21st February, 2026 marked International Mother Language Day, a global celebration of linguistic diversity. UNESCO reminds us that preserving local languages is essential to prevent their extinction. This year’s theme, “Youth Voices on Multilingual Education,” underscores the importance of the fact that our young people are not just inheritors of Ghana’s linguistic diversity; they are its future custodians. By empowering them to learn, innovate and express themselves in their mother tongues, we ensure Ghana’s languages thrive in classrooms, communities, and digital spaces. In the Ghanaian Context, our mother tongue is more than identity; it embodies the pride of our history, oral traditions and collective memory.

Mr Speaker, if I say “Miawoe zo,” you instantly recognise not only who I am, but also the heritage I represent. This mother tongue, as a source of identity, must also be our path for education.

Our current Vice President for the Republic of Ghana and former Minister for Education, Prof Jane Naana Opoku-Agyemang, has written and advocated for the need for children to be taught in their mother tongue from birth. Building on this, the current Minister for Education, Hon Haruna Iddrisu, has also emphasised the need for children to be taught their local language from Kindergarten through Basic 3. By beginning education in the language of the child’s heart, we lay a strong foundation for confidence, literacy, and lifelong learning. This emphasis is reinforced by UNESCO’s research, which shows globally that 40 per cent of learners lack access to education in their mother tongue.

In some low- and middle-income countries, this figure rises to 90 per cent. Neglecting indigenous languages undermines both literacy development and cultural identity, making Hon Haruna’s call even more urgent.

UNESCO guidance further affirms that our first language (L1) forms the foundation for acquiring second languages (L2). No child should be mocked for excelling more in L1 than L2. Accents in English are natural, as some sounds simply do not exist in our mother tongues. Instead of ridicule, we must celebrate this diversity, for it builds confidence and strengthens language preservation.

Mr Speaker, the growing dominance of English at home accelerates the erosion of local languages. Without intervention, smaller Ghanaian languages risk vanishing, causing cultural amnesia. Resource gaps like inadequate teaching materials and teacher training further hinder mother-tongue education.

Hon Members, Ghana must embrace bilingualism. English connects us globally; our indigenous languages root us in identity. To be Ghanaian is to harmonise the global and the local.

As Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts, I take pride in speaking five Ghanaian languages. This is not just a skill; it is my self-worth and identity, enabling me to connect with diverse communities and showcase Ghana's cultural richness worldwide.

In the era of Artificial Intelligence (AI), technology offers powerful tools to empower our languages. AI can:

- Enable speech recognition in Twi, Ga, Ewe, Dagbani, and other Ghanaian languages.
- Power machine translation between Ghanaian and global languages.
- Provide text-to-speech and speech-to-text tools for inclusive education and governance.
- Digitise and archive oral traditions, folklore, and proverbs.

- Expand financial inclusion via mobile banking in local languages.
- Support digital education, telemedicine, and agricultural advisories in indigenous tongues.

In the AI economy, language data is infrastructure. Ghanaian linguistic datasets are national assets. Investing in them empowers local startups, bolsters digital sovereignty and creates tech jobs.

Hon Members, let us unite to:

- Expand mother-tongue-based multilingual education nationwide.
- Invest in digital infrastructure for Ghanaian languages.
- Establish national language data repositories for AI development.
- Incentivise tech startups building AI tools in local languages. Integrate Ghanaian languages into public digital services.
- Support media, publishing and content creation in indigenous languages.

Preserving Ghanaian languages is nation-building in the digital age, not mere nostalgia. It ensures every Ghanaian child can learn, innovate and

thrive in the language of their heart. Let this august House be remembered as the one that secured Ghana's many voices, both in books and bytes. Align with UNESCO's call to amplify youth voices in multilingual education, so that the next generation carries our heritage proudly forward. For as long as our languages endure in libraries or AI systems, the heartbeat of Ghana will remain strong, proud and eternal.

Akpe. Barika. Me da ase. Oye wala don.

[Published by order of Mr Speaker]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then I give the Floor to Hon Alhassan Umar, Member of Parliament for Zabzugu. But before taking the Floor, let me use two minutes to stretch my legs. The House is suspended for two minutes.

3:27 p.m. — *Sitting Suspended*

3:29 p.m. — *Sitting Resumed*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, kindly resume your seats.

Yes, Mr Alhassan Umar, you have the Floor.

Urgent Need to Address Deceptive Warranty Practices and Strengthen Consumer Rights Protection in Ghana

Mr Alhassan Umar (NDC — Zabzugu): Mr Speaker, I rise before this esteemed House today to draw its urgent

attention to a matter that undermines fair commerce and the rights of the ordinary Ghanaian consumer: the widespread and damaging issue of deceptive warranty practices.

Mr Speaker, a warranty, in its essence, is a legally binding promise. It is an assurance from a manufacturer or seller to a consumer asserting that a product meets specific quality standards, performance, and reliability for a stated period. It gives the consumer a safety net or guarantees him of a remedy if the product fails to meet the set standards — it could be a repair, a replacement, or a refund. This layer of trust, on which commerce relies, is fundamental to a healthy and fair marketplace.

Mr Speaker, there are generally two forms of warranties: the expressed warranty, usually explicitly stated in writing or by verbal communication and the implied warranty — a guarantee imposed by law declaring a product to be fit for its intended purpose and of marketable quality. However, Mr Speaker, the breach of this agreement, through the misrepresentation of a warranty, constitutes a deceptive trade practice and a clear breach of contract. It does not only erode consumer confidence in the market but it also undermines the integrity and trustworthiness of our commercial landscape.

Mr Speaker, permit me to underscore some common manifestations of deceptive warranty practices for the benefit of the House.

False Advertising: The making of misleading claims about a product's warranty, including spreading inaccurate information regarding the duration, scope of coverage, or the conditions attached to the warranty of a product.

Void if Removed Stickers: This involves affixing seals to products and then asserting that a warranty is void if the seal is broken. It is, however, instructive to note that this practice has been declared illegal by international bodies like the United States Federal Trade Commission (FTC), given that the attempt to void warranties based on a consumer's right to inspect or repair a product constitutes a clear and apparent violation of their rights.

Conditioning Warranty on Proprietary Parts: A retailer cannot lawfully declare a warranty void simply because a consumer uses non-proprietary parts or seeks repairs from an independent service provider, unless those specific parts or services were provided free of charge.

Refusal to Honour Implied Warranties: While a retailer may state that a product is sold "as is," they cannot, under sound legal principles, disclaim the implied warranties of merchantability and fitness if they concurrently offer a written warranty. Mr Speaker, the worse part of this troubling reality is that, while many retailers readily issue both expressed and implied warranties on products at the point of sale, they subsequently fail to honour these

commitments, resort to shifting goalposts and evade their stated responsibilities.

3:33 p.m.

Mr Speaker, allow me to provide some personal examples that I believe are emblematic of the experiences of countless Ghanaians, and which will paint a classical picture and illustrate this national malady. On 15th August, 2020, I bought a fully automatic washing machine in Accra from a retailer whose name I withhold. The warranty of this product was expressly inscribed on both the product and on the retailer's official receipt, "warranty for 1 year." However, in less than a year, the machine developed a problem that qualified for the redress by the retailer of his explicit promise made at the point of sale, became a subject of negotiation and excuses. Mr Speaker, let me say, on authority that this is not an isolated incident. If an Hon Member of this august House can face such brazen disregard for consumer rights, what then is the fate of our ordinary people?

From the foregoing, Mr Speaker, the question that must seize the attention of this House is how many of our citizens are being systematically deceived and defrauded daily, without any effective recourse under our statutes?

Mr Speaker, to conclude, the current situation is untenable. The legal and regulatory frameworks that are supposed to protect the Ghanaian consumer from such deceptive warranty practices are scattered in various Acts of Parliament

and policy documents. What is required is the immediate consolidation, strengthening, and rigorous enforcement of a single Act of Parliament on consumer rights protection. Mr Speaker, the trust between the consumer and the seller is a cornerstone of a modern and thriving economy. When that trust is broken, it is not just an individual who loses; our entire national economic fabric is weakened.

Thank you for your time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that is the Statement. It is now time for comments. Is anybody ready for comments?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker we will let it go.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, no comments.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, we will move to the Statement (j), standing in the name of Hon Maxwell Kwame Lukutor. Once he is not here, I will direct that the Statement be published.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am sure he is going to do some survey somewhere.
[Laughter]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I direct the Statement be published in the *Hansard*.

The Deteriorating State of the Sogakope Bridge and the Urgent Need for Comprehensive Maintenance and Rehabilitation

Ing Surv Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (NDC — South Tongu): Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to make this Statement on a matter of urgent public and national importance - namely, the deteriorating condition of the Sogakope Bridge and the attendant risks it poses to public safety, economic activity and national security.

Mr Speaker, the Sogakope Bridge is one of Ghana's most strategic transport infrastructures. It serves as a vital link between the southern and northern corridors of the Volta Region and remains indispensable to the movement of people, goods and services from Togo, Nigeria, Benin, across the region and beyond. Its continued structural integrity is therefore a matter of national interest.

Mr Speaker, somewhere in 2017, there were numerous accidents which resulted in demonstrations and several meetings with the Regional Coordinating Council of the Volta Region. In response to the above, a temporary measure was taken to seal the expansion joints instead of replacing the element.

Mr Speaker, there was also an assurance of the rehabilitation works awarded on contract and was evidenced by site clearing and loading as a sign of commencement of the project but till date nothing has been heard regarding the repair works.

Mr Speaker, in recent months, the attention of my office has been drawn to growing public concern over the worsening condition of the bridge, particularly reports of accidents and near-fatal incidents. In response, and in the discharge of my constitutional duty as a Member of this honourable House, I earlier raised questions on the floor of Parliament regarding the state of the bridge, with specific reference to the condition of the expansion joints, metal railings, pedestrian walkways, and the deterioration of the bituminous surface.

To ascertain the extent of the deterioration and assess the risks involved, I, together with the District Chief Executive for South Tongu, Hon Victoria Dzeklo, undertook a joint technical inspection of the bridge. The inspection team included the Southern Regional Engineer of the Department of Roads and Highways, the District Engineer, and a Technical Officer from the District Town and Country Planning Department.

Mr Speaker, the inspection confirmed that the condition of the bridge is indeed alarming. The expansion joints, which were temporarily sealed with bitumen, since 2017 have deteriorated significantly. The bitumen wears off easily, resulting in deep potholes around the expansion gaps. These defects pose a serious hazard to motorists and have been linked to several accidents on the bridge, some of which have tragically resulted in loss of lives.

Mr Speaker, the inspection further revealed that the pedestrian walkway is

in a deplorable state. The metal plates originally installed have deteriorated extensively, with some having been removed entirely. This has left open gaps and exposed, corroded metal components, creating a serious safety risk to pedestrians, including schoolchildren, traders and daily commuters.

Additionally, Mr Speaker, the concrete slabs adjoining the main carriageway have deteriorated badly, further compromising the safety of road users. The metal railings along the bridge are also extensively damaged, increasing the risk of pedestrians falling into the Volta River, particularly during nighttime and periods of heavy traffic.

Mr Speaker, a further matter of grave concern is the malfunctioning of the bridge's street lighting system. Out of the 28 streetlights installed on the bridge, only seven are currently operational. This inadequate lighting has rendered the bridge unsafe at night and has facilitated criminal activities, including the theft of electrical cables and metal components.

Mr Speaker, following the inspection, the Southern Regional Engineer of the Department of Roads and Highways, Mr Nathaniel, contacted the Director at the Head Office, during which the District Chief Executive and I engaged the Director directly. We were advised to formally submit a letter to initiate the maintenance process, and we were assured that a technical team would be deployed in the coming week to conduct a comprehensive assessment as a precursor to remedial works.

Mr Speaker, while this assurance is welcomed, I wish to stress that the condition of the Sogakope Bridge requires urgent, comprehensive, and sustained intervention. Temporary or palliative measures will no longer suffice. What is required is a full rehabilitation of the expansion joints, pedestrian walkways, concrete slabs, metal railings, and the complete restoration of the street lighting system.

Mr Speaker, beyond structural repairs, I also wish to draw the attention of this honourable House to the need for enhanced security on the bridge. In collaboration with the District Chief Executive, we have proposed the installation of closed-circuit television (CCTV) surveillance systems to provide 24-hour monitoring and to deter vandalism and theft of public infrastructure.

The Sogakope Bridge is not only a transport facility but also a national landmark with significant tourism potential. Regular maintenance, cleaning, and beautification will not only enhance safety but also improve its aesthetic appeal and contribute to tourism development in the Volta Region as it has the enviable record of being the longest bridge in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, I therefore respectfully call on the Ministry of Roads and Highways, the Department of Roads and Highways, and all relevant State institutions to treat this matter with the urgency and seriousness it deserves. The lives of Ghanaians must not be imperiled by avoidable infrastructure neglect.

I assure this honourable House of my continued commitment, working closely with the District Chief Executive and all relevant stakeholders, to ensure the safety, durability, and long-term maintenance of the Sogakope Bridge for the benefit of present and future generations.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Now Statement numbered (k) in the name of Hon Emelia Ankomah, Member of Parliament for Upper Denkyira East. You have the floor.

International Day of Zero Tolerance for Female Genital Mutilation

Ms Emelia Ankomah (NDC — Upper Denkyira East): Mr Speaker, I rise to mark the International Day of Zero Tolerance for Female Genital Mutilation, observed on 6th February in accordance with United Nations General Assembly Resolution A/RES/67/146.

Mr Speaker, this day compels us not only to remember, but to reflect honestly on whether our actions as a nation match our declarations. Female Genital Mutilation (FGM) is a harmful practice involving the partial or total removal of female genitalia for non-medical reasons. It has no health benefit, no scientific basis, and no moral justification. It is a clear violation of the fundamental human rights of women and girls.

Mr Speaker, the consequences are devastating and lifelong: severe bleeding, infections, childbirth complications, psychological trauma, and in some cases, death. Yet beyond these physical harms lies an even deeper injustice: the denial of dignity, bodily autonomy, and choice to the girl child.

Mr Speaker, Ghana has taken a strong legal position. The Criminal Offences Act, 1960 (Act 29), as amended, criminalises FGM and prescribes sanctions for perpetrators and accomplices. However, Mr Speaker, laws alone do not change behaviour. If they did, this practice would no longer exist within our borders. The persistence of FGM in some communities raises uncomfortable but necessary questions about enforcement, accountability, and our collective resolve. Mr Speaker, are we doing enough to protect the most vulnerable girls in remote and marginalised communities? Are institutions mandated to enforce the law sufficiently resourced? Are we, as leaders, bold enough to confront harmful practices even when they are shielded by silence and social pressure?

Mr Speaker, I wish to state unequivocally that there is no cultural, traditional, or religious justification for Female Genital Mutilation. Culture is not static. Any practice that endangers life and dehumanises women must be confronted and abandoned. Traditional and religious leaders therefore have a critical role to play in reshaping attitudes and safeguarding the next generation.

Mr Speaker, survivors of FGM must also be placed at the centre of our national response. They require access to healthcare, psychosocial support, legal protection, and economic empowerment. Their lived experiences should inform our policies, not remain hidden in shame and fear.

Mr Speaker, as parliamentarians, this day challenges us to go beyond symbolic condemnation. It calls on us to strengthen oversight, support targeted education, empower communities, and demand effective enforcement of the law. Zero tolerance must be reflected not only in our words, but in measurable action.

Mr Speaker, as we observe this day in 2026, let us recommit ourselves to building a Ghana where no girl is subjected to harmful practices, where her rights are protected, and where her future is determined by choice and not by violence disguised as tradition.

Mr Speaker, I urge this honourable House to reaffirm its zero-tolerance stance on Female Genital Mutilation and to contribute actively to the national effort to eradicate it completely.

Mr Speaker, I so submit. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, it is now time for comments.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I was hoping that Hon Baffour would contribute—

[Expunged by the order of Mr Speaker]—

[*Laughter*] He is an advocate for FGM folks.

Mr Speaker, Female Genital Mutilation is not a cultural practice. It is a human right violation. A larger chunk of young beautiful women—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Human right violation, yet you said someone is a specialist in that?

Mr Shaib: Yes, Mr Speaker, he is an advocate for FGM victims. [*Laughter*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: There is an application for same to be expunged from the record. Same is ordered to be expunged.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, as I started saying, it is not a cultural practice. It is a human right violation. Mr Speaker, over 230 million young beautiful women will have to go through this very painful process. Mr Speaker, sometimes we give all manner of excuses for these young women to go through this process.

3:43 p.m.

First of all, when we look at the 2026 theme, "Towards 2030: No End to FGM Without Sustained Commitment and Investment", it is a direct indictment of governments, that most governments have made so much noise about FGM, but the ability to sponsor to ensure that it is eradicated is missing. We make a lot of noise, have a lot of talk shows and have a lot of seminars on FGM, but just to have some sort of budget to prosecute issues on FGM is dead on arrival *ab initio*.

Mr Speaker, the consequences of FGM abound, including Sexually Transmitted Diseases (STDs), and haemorrhage. There are cumulative and lifelong challenges when people go through FGM. Some of them even go through the risk of childbirth complications. Yet, in modern times, we are still encouraging FGM. Some even have to endure infertility just because of FGM.

So, the call now is that let us try and sponsor the prosecution of FGM so that it is eradicated. As I said, it is not a matter of culture; it is a matter of breach of human rights. We have a lot of people going through this. The scale of this crisis demands that it has become a public health matter. When ladies are giving birth, and the next thing is that—

Mr Speaker, there is also a scientific understanding that just because of this FGM, some women have issues of low libido. At least I have had engagement with some women. They will tell us, and we can ask and ask again. They will let us understand that the issues of libido is restrained because they have had FGM.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, my available Leader is speaking from experience. [*Laughter*]

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am speaking because I have read on it. When one has friends who can educate on same, one should be very well abreast of the facts. We are not making progress fast enough. We must say so plainly that it is sometimes even seen as political. There is no political

wherewithal or capacity to have these things dealt with, because there is a Member of Parliament or there is a President who finds it difficult to deal with the matter because of votes to the detriment of these young lives that we are talking about.

Mr Speaker, let me just re-enumerate the situations they would have to find themselves in. Infertility is one. Not having libido is another. STDs is another. If we do not put a stop to this, then we do not know what is going to happen in the next—

Mr James Agalga (NDC — Builsa North): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity. A while ago, I was asking my Colleague who is a medical doctor whether it is indeed true that FGM is one of the causes of the low libido in women. I did not get a response, but Hon Ahmed has clarified the matter.

But, on a more serious note, to say FGM is not a cultural practice, but a human rights violation *simpliciter*, in my view, may not be very accurate. The reason is that until a law was passed in this country to outlaw FGM, it was prevalent in some communities in this country. In fact, the prevalence rate was so high to the extent that in some communities and cultures, women voluntarily lined up to undergo FGM in order to avoid stigma. So, it was a cultural practice, which has now been outlawed. The fact that that cultural practice has now been outlawed elevates the practice to the level of the violation of the fundamental human rights of the victims of FGM.

Mr Speaker, I say so because if we fail to admit that FGM was a cultural practice amongst some communities in our country, we would have issues with sensitisation. Insofar as people would line up voluntarily to undergo FGM, they are matters we need to contend with. If we do not engage in sensitisation, we may have issues enforcing the very law Parliament passed to outlaw the practice.

So, Mr Speaker, in adding my voice and thanking the maker of the Statement, I would implore this House to take measures to ensure that the agencies of State such as the National Commission for Civic Education (NCCE), which are charged with the responsibility of sensitising the public on the dos and don'ts of certain civic responsibilities, take up the challenge seriously. This is so that communities in which the practice was prevalent, would begin to sensitise would-be victims of FGM, that there is nothing like stigma if one does not mutilate one's genitals. There is no stigmatisation at all.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, bear with me. I am being accused of being gender insensitive, so I will give the floor to Hon Zanetor.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, when I said somebody is an expert, you did not want to agree. When Hon Zanetor is done, the expert still wants to have a bite on this matter. It is just a humble prayer.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, should we do the restoration of your words in the *Hansard*?

Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings (NDC — Klottey-Korle): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by the Hon Member.

Mr Speaker, the issue of Female Genital Mutilation is not just one that occurs in Ghana. It occurs across the continent of Africa and some parts of the Far East as well, in Asia. So, this is actually a global issue. Yes, indeed, it is a violation of the rights of women.

Some of the conditions that occur – in my personal experience in hospital, I remember witnessing the difficulty that some women went through during childbirth, where what should have been a straightforward vaginal childbirth became very complicated, requiring forceps, episiotomy, and in some cases, an emergency caesarean section because of scarring and the inability of the tissues to expand, to accommodate the emergent head of the baby.

Mr Speaker, some of the other conditions that occur include fistula, where one has a connection forming between the vagina and other parts of the body, whether within the bladder or into the rectum as well. These cause a lot of infections amongst those who have had these procedures done. So, Mr Speaker, there are real health concerns around this issue beyond the issues of sexual pleasure that obviously are limited by this practice.

I think that the maker of this Statement having mentioned that today

is about an international recognition of this condition, the issue of stakeholder engagement is key, the enforcement of law and political will is key. It could not have happened in Ghana without political will. I believe that, that is perhaps what the Second Deputy Minority Whip was making reference to when it comes to the issue of the push that is required.

3:53 p.m.

If the laws are in place, if we engage stakeholders but we cannot get that level of political will to actually push for this to happen and for these practices to be outlawed, we will have generations of young women who are presenting with various complications during pregnancy and afterwards, increased risk of sexually transmitted diseases and a lot of other associated issues.

Mr Speaker, the sooner we address these issues — because if in 2026, we are still speaking to these issues, then I think the issue of women's rights as fundamental human rights really needs to be considered as a matter of urgency. I urge this House to perhaps take advantage of this to improve their knowledge and be advocates wherever they find themselves to ensure that this harmful practice is abolished, not just here, not just across the continent, but across the world.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am told you are a specialist, so I have to give you the floor.

You have the floor.

Mr Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah (NPP — Manhyia South): Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for the opportunity. Whenever FGM is mentioned, the 31st December Women's Movement comes to mind. This is because they did a lot of activism in the past to ensure that this whole practice is outlawed. Mr Speaker, I also remember very well that it was part of the reasons when President Kufuor was inaugurated as President of this country, he established the Ministry of Women and Children Affairs. But it looks like the Ministry has now become more interested in school feeding and the business side of it, rather than fighting for the real interests of children and women in our society.

Mr Speaker, from the perspective of my available Leader, the Chief Whip and Hon Zanetor, it is obvious that what is lacking is the political will. But it is not just the political will; it is also about the person who would ensure that the interests of the women and children are protected, which, in this case, is the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection. Mr Speaker, it may be necessary in the circumstances to refocus the Ministry on the real affairs of children and women. When I say this, I am not limiting it to this particular administration. But every now and then, we see children loitering from different African countries on our streets. Mr Speaker, it appears that we have been let down in that area, so it is about time the Ministry is seen to be up and doing to ensure that this practice completely becomes a thing of the past.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to a Statement standing in the name of Hon Dr Mohammed Sherif Abdul-Khaliq, Member of Parliament for Nanton.

Emergency Care Deficit in Ghana

Dr Abdul-Khaliq Mohammed Sherif (NDC — Nanton): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity to bring this Statement, which is on the emergency care deficit in Ghana. Mr Speaker, I rise today, not only as a Member of Parliament, but also as a medical doctor, to draw your attention to a matter of life and death, which is the growing emergency care deficit in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, emergency care is not a luxury. It is a fundamental pillar of every functional health system. When a pregnant woman haemorrhages in labour, when a child is in respiratory distress, when a young man is involved in a road traffic accident, or when a patient collapses from a stroke or heart attack, the difference between life and death is measured in minutes. On 6th February, 2026, a 29-year-old engineer, Mr Charles Amissah, lost his life following a hit-and-run accident on the highway in Accra. Reports indicate that the emergency medical technicians responded within minutes and administered care according to standard protocols. Yet, after being transported to three major hospitals in the capital, which are the Police Hospital, Greater Accra Hospital, and the Korle-bu

Teaching Hospital, he was allegedly declined admission and emergency stabilisation due to what is known as the “no-bed syndrome”. My deepest condolences to the bereaved family. The Minister for Health has constituted a committee, which is chaired by himself, to look into the circumstances surrounding his death and then make appropriate recommendations.

While we commend the efforts of the Government and agencies such as the National Ambulance Service (NAS), the reality on the ground reveals significant gaps that demand immediate policy attention. Mr Speaker, Ghana continues to face inadequate ambulance coverage. Many districts still lack reliable ambulance services. Response times, especially in rural constituencies like mine in Nanton, remain unacceptably long. We also face the issue of poorly equipped emergency units. Several district hospitals and health centres lack basic resource station equipment, defibrillators, ventilators, oxygen supply systems and trauma care logistics. Human resource constraints are another. We have an insufficient number of trained emergency physicians, paramedics and other critical care nurses. In many facilities, emergency units are managed by overstretched general staff without specialised training. Also, we have weak referral systems. Delays in referrals, with a lack of communication between facilities and the absence of a coordinated trauma network, contribute significantly to preventable deaths. Then the issue of financial barriers. Despite the mandate of the National Health Insurance Authority (NHIA), many

emergency interventions require out-of-pocket payment before care is administered, undermining the very principle that emergency care should never be denied.

Mr Speaker, road traffic accidents, obstetric emergencies, cardiovascular diseases and acute infections continue to claim thousands of lives annually. According to the global health standards, effective emergency systems can prevent up to 50 per cent of deaths from trauma and acute medical conditions. We must therefore act decisively.

I respectfully propose the following: the establishment of a National Emergency Care Policy Framework with clear funding lines; a dedicated budgetary allocation for emergency infrastructure in all regional and district hospitals; expansion and modernisation of the NAS fleet with equitable rural distribution; training and certification programmes in emergency medicine and trauma care; enforcement of laws prohibiting refusal of emergency care based on inability to pay; development of a centralised emergency call and dispatch coordination system nationwide; and lastly, we must also include the training of Basic Life Support (BLS) in the curriculum of junior and senior high school students.

Mr Speaker, emergency care is the frontline of universal health coverage. If we are committed to achieving Sustainable Development Goal 3 (SDG 3) and improving health outcomes for our citizens, then strengthening emergency care must be treated as a

national priority. As a medical practitioner, I have witnessed first-hand the heartbreak of preventable deaths due to delays and system failures. As representatives of the people, I believe we have the power and the responsibility to change this narrative. Let us not wait for the next tragedy to act. Let us invest today in systems that save lives tomorrow.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr John Darko (NPP — Suame):

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement made by my Brother. I did not know he is a medical doctor. Thank you, my Brother, for this very insightful Statement. I am looking at the last line of his Statement in which he implores us, as the people's representative, not to wait for the next tragedy before we act. And so, I ask, 40 days since this tragic incident that happened to Mr Charles Amissah, what has happened? My Colleague mentioned that the Minister for Health has set up a committee to be chaired by the Minister himself and 40 days after the unfortunate demise of our compatriots, there is no report. That is why I believe that his Statement is very important.

4:03 p.m.

Let us not wait for the next tragedy to act. This is a country where we celebrate a lot of things. For instance, Mr Speaker, our President and the current Administration have celebrated the fact

that Ghanaian physicians are being sent away to the Caribbeans. My Brother, the doctor, says one of the reasons people are dying from lack of emergency care is the constraints in human resource. We do not have doctors, we do not have enough nurses, we do not have enough physicians to take care of Ghanaians. Yet we celebrate the fact that we are shipping Ghanaians out of this country. We are shipping nurses, we are shipping doctors, we are shipping physicians out of this country to go to the Caribbeans to take care of people. We celebrate that, when Ghanaians are dying from this absence of physicians. This is what we celebrate as a people. So, the Statement from my Brother is very important.

Mr Speaker, may Hon Dafeamekpor refrain from interjecting my comment. Mr Speaker, this is a country where we have trained so many nurses who are looking for employment. The Minister for Finance is not giving financial clarity for those people to be employed. It is the reason why people are dying from this problem, emergency care deficit. We do not have the human resources. Doctors complete training and they are not posted. When you are sick or when you get involved in an accident and you go to the hospital, you are looking for a physician to help you. We are not posting them. And we are here issuing a Statement. The Statement by my Brother is timely. But this Statement should go to the present Government, employ the people who are seeking for jobs.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon John Darko, be guided by Order 93(5).

Mr Darko: Thank you, Mr Speaker, I am guided.

Mr Speaker, one of the things my Brother stated is that we have inadequate ambulance coverage. The previous administration acquired 307 ambulances. We are told that 127 of them are in a state of disrepair. They are not working. How do we treat emergency care when our ambulances are destroyed and we are not fixing them? That is a problem. So, the Statement by my Colleague is timely, but it should go to the Government to fix our ambulances for us. Because when people are involved in an accident, they want to call the ambulance service.

Mr Speaker, the problem really is that we do not even know the number to call when we are involved in any emergency situation. Mr Speaker, you can ask Members of this House. My Brother, the Hon Majority Chief Whip, if he is involved in an accident right now, which number is he going to call? We need to educate ourselves, and because he does not know, he cannot speak to his people. We need to speak. We need to train the people. So, 112 should be a number that should be made known to the people of Ghana so that when they have an emergency, they can should call.

Mr Speaker, on that note, I want to thank my Brother, the maker of the Statement, for this insightful Statement. I hope that his recommendations are implemented by the Government to save the people of Ghana from avoidable death.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leadership, you are yielding?

Hon Majority Chief Whip, we have reached some agreement in your absence. So, confer with your Deputy.

Yes, Hon Zanetor?

Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings (NDC — Klottey Korle): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement made by the Hon Member on the emergency care deficit in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, emergency care is a specialist area, and the deficit is one that would have to be addressed through policy and definitely in terms of a quota system, where there is a proper assessment of what the deficit is in order to encourage more, I suppose, medical students to veer into that direction. Having said so, Mr Speaker, I would like to also add my voice to the need for basic life support training for not just the students in secondary school, but all first responders, including the police officers and other security service personnel. And of course, importantly, members of the Ghana Private Road Transport Union (GPRTU), especially drivers and their “mates”, as a very important part because when these accidents happen, they usually tend to be the ones who are first on the scene. The first hour following any kind of trauma is critical, and the kind of processes that are followed are important towards the preservation and quality of life thereafter.

Mr Speaker, I think that in addition to that, the training of our paramedics in advanced cardiac and trauma life support are key. So that in the process of transporting patients from the site of an incident to whichever health facility is catered for enroute, because that is also essential in terms of the saving of lives.

Mr Speaker, I would like to use the opportunity to encourage the public that there are certain things to look out for when you come into a situation of an accident of this sort, where there are no responders around. There is what we call the ABCs; the airway, breathing and circulation. That has to do with whether the patient is first of all conscious, very importantly, whether the area that you are approaching is safe to approach, and also, to assess whether the person is alert. In doing so, one should also take cognisance of the fact that there could be an injury to the spine, and to be very careful that in trying to transport the person from the site of injury to a safer position, you are not actually exacerbating the injury. Sometimes you witness when people are being rescued from a vehicle or some site of an accident, the way they are even carried, more than likely results in certain injuries being made worse. So, a sensitisation of the public on a basic appreciation of what a person looks like and what to look out for in the event of an accident is key.

I think that given the fact that Parliament has paramedics posted here, it might be worthwhile for Members of Parliament to perhaps be given an opportunity to understand what basic life

support is, so that even among us, we can also serve as first responders in the event of anything. Luckily, we have some of our staff always seated in the Chamber. And they are also positioned in the gymnasium for the Members of Parliament who work out, which is very few. I would like to take the opportunity to urge Members to take their exercise very seriously, to make sure that their blood pressure and sugar levels are being checked, given the level of stress that Members are exposed to. And perhaps, to appeal to the Rt Hon Speaker to look at the extended hours of Sitting in the House deep into the night. It is not in the interest of the health of, not just Members of Parliament, but of all members of staff, not only from the point of view of nutrition and eating late and its impact on our metabolism, but also, on the safety and security of staff who have to leave the premises at a very late hour to get home, in which case some may even be exposed to the risk of accidents, which puts them back into the cycle of this deficit of healthcare in terms of trauma life support.

Mr Speaker, I think that as a House, we need to really look at this. We have seen in the last perhaps four years alone, occasions where Members and visitors who have been in the Chamber have either lost consciousness or had need to be seen to quite urgently. And at times, you witness the lack of experience in how people rush in on the person in need of emergency medical attention.

4:13 p.m.

So certainly, the issue of the basic life support cannot be overemphasised. All persons as much as possible should be

educated on basic life support, or at the very least, first aid and what to do and what not to do in order to preserve and protect life while we wait for patients to be transported from the—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, emergency care is not a luxury. It is actually the frontline defence against death. Where you have over 54 million people who die anyhow anyway just because they did not get emergency care is something one has to be worried about. We are aware that emergency care —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Did you say 54 million?

Mr Shaib: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Within which period?

Mr Shaib: I am talking about a global figure not Ghana. This indication is a reason for us to consider emergency care as a very important factor or step in health provision. Emergency care is in three forms: the pre-hospital care, the in-facility emergency medicine, and post emergency or critical care. When attention is paid to emergency care, the very basic things that hitherto would have caused problems, can be prevented. I think that one of the problems we have is actually education on how to deal with some of the situations that arise. For instance, in recent times I was giving out fuel coupons to motor riders and taxi drivers. I got burnt by the exhaust of a

motor rider and just there, the kind of medical care and attention I had varied. In fact, everybody became a doctor. Some said I should use salt water, some said warm water and others said I should use vaseline. Mr Speaker, what it means is that even for us, we do not have the basics apart from the structures which most of them are unavailable.

Mr Speaker, my Colleague here made reference to the issue of ambulances. Most MPs will tell you that their ambulances are dysfunctional. They have been decommissioned. They are not working. Members of Parliament have now become the ones to fix the ambulances and you ask yourself if there are no budgetary allocations to service ambulances and to get them in good and proper condition so that whenever there are situations of emergency, those ambulances could be used.

Mr Speaker, in Ghana, emergency care spans from the National Ambulance Service, hospital accident and emergency units, Police and Fire Services first post response protocols and community level health facilities, all of which are operating under the conditions of under resourced. It has become chronic and there is structural neglect. There is also another aspect of the workforce—I have information that since 2021, a lot of nurses that qualified to start working in facilities especially government facilities are unable to work. This is because first of all, maybe there is unavailability of those facilities for them to even be employed; second, they do not get the financial clearance. *[Interruption]* I do not do politics when I

am doing these things. If it is 2021 and they did not get the financial clearance, we are in 2026 so what are we waiting for? We need them to get jobs. Let them have access. Let them not become people who may have acquired the necessary knowledge and then become rusty because they may not be training and not getting— unlike lawyers who may perhaps be getting a chamber to operate from, they are just sitting in their homes and not doing anything. We need all of these people employed. When they are employed, it will give recourse to emergency care. They will be doing something. They will be working and this is something that when we are able to do, will save a lot of lives.

Mr Speaker, another thing is also to rehabilitate —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me thank the Hon Abdul-Khaliq for bringing this very important matter once more. It appears to be a Statement that finds space on this floor every year. Mr Speaker, between Somanya and Hohoe, a distance of 168 km, there is no accident centre. There is no accident centre on that stretch of the eastern corridor. And indeed, there is no hospital properly so-called situated on that stretch apart from the Peki Government Hospital. So the Peki Government Hospital is inundated with emergency cases. Apart from road crashes that lead to such emergency cases, we also have emergency cases that are referred from other health centres that serve as the catchment area and feed

on the hospital. So, using my area alone, it is such an important aspect of our health care.

Mr speaker, there is no accident centre also on the stretch between the Sogakope Hospital and your capital, Akatsi, so if there is a road crash, depending on the distance, they are either rushed to your place or they come to Sogakope. And we know what happens when you are transporting injured accident victims in a certain way and in a rush. So, this is such a major matter that this House should be concerned with.

Mr Speaker, there are major construction works happening on our very major arterial roads. I am happy the Leader has come. Maybe we should be asking that in addition to delivering these major roads, it should be consequential that we build well-resourced accident centres. It does not take much to do these things these days. There are even technologies available that are nicely done and become a first port of call to saving lives.

Mr speaker, two, as for the ambulance politics, we can do it but I do not want to do it this afternoon. We need to find out what is happening to the service agreement that was consequential to delivering the ambulances because the vehicles ought to be serviced regularly. It is part of the agreement. I know that there is an existing agreement as part of the entire ambulance supply issue. If that is not happening, then we must not be relying on ambulance alone in responding to our emergency situations. Can we look at

delivering two helicopters, for instance, air ambulance as is done in other countries? Mr Speaker, we get the opportunity to travel and we benchmark. I like to reference Tanzania because they are doing things very well. Between Zanzibar and Tanzania, it is one hour by sea, that is, water taxi. When you are in a water bus, it is like two hours. Now by air, it is 25 minutes if you are in a helicopter or in an ambulance,

4:23 p.m.

They use the air, they call it an air ambulance, to ferry patients onto the mainland in Dar es Salaam for medical response to emergency situations. It is a well-run system. We need to begin to think along those lines that we need two helicopters as an air ambulance on standby, so that, depending on what is happening — because response time, Mr Speaker, is also critical. If the response time is good, a lot of lives will be saved. But the response time also depends on logistical availability. So, if we are able to have the logistics to be able to respond timeously, we lift victims when they are injured quickly to centres to be attended to.

So I do not know whether, Mr Speaker, we may pray you to refer this to the Committee on Health, to come back, to consider this important Statement and see how, as Parliament, we can give some directives to enhance our—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, we then move to the last Statement, which stands in the name of Mr Misbahu, Mahama Adams, MP for Mion, I guess

he is not in. I would direct that his Statement be published in the *Hansard*.

Leveraging Local Player Inclusion for National Football Development

Mr Misbahu Mahama Adams (NDC—Mion): Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to make this Statement on an issue of considerable national importance, that is, the need for a deliberate and forward-looking policy to ensure the inclusion of locally based footballers in Ghana's senior national football team, the Black Stars, as we intensify preparations towards participating in the FIFA World Cup 2026. And on this note, I congratulate the Black Stars and its management for qualifying. It is our hope that we become the first African country to win the trophy.

Mr Speaker, football remains one of the most powerful unifying forces in our country. Beyond its entertainment value, it serves as a significant vehicle for national pride, youth empowerment, employment generation and economic activity. However, while we celebrate the achievements of our national team on the global stage, it is imperative that we equally examine how we participate in the FIFA World Cup 2026 to stimulate growth within our domestic football ecosystem.

Mr Speaker, the world governing body of football, FIFA, in partnership with the European Club Association, has introduced an enhanced edition of the FIFA Club Benefits Programme to be implemented for the 2026 World Cup.

Under this revised framework, a record sum of Three Hundred and Fifty-Five Million United States Dollars (US\$355 million) will be distributed globally to football clubs that release players for national team assignments in relation to the World Cup tournament. This marks a historic and progressive shift in the global football financing model. Unlike previous editions of the programme, where compensation was limited only to clubs whose players participated in the final tournament, the new arrangement extends financial benefits to clubs that release players for World Cup matches, regardless of whether those players ultimately participate in the tournament itself.

This development, Mr Speaker, has profound implications for Ghana. Payments under the Club Benefits Programme are calculated based on a daily rate for each player during the period of national team engagement and are subsequently distributed among the clubs with which such players play. In essence, every time a locally based player is invited to represent Ghana in a World Cup match, his club stands to receive financial compensation from FIFA. For instance, if a player(s) from Sankara Nationals FC, Karela United FC, or Real Tamale United get called up by the Black Stars to participate in the 2026 World Cup, their various clubs benefit financially, which in turn stimulates the growth of our local leagues.

Mr Speaker, this presents Ghana with a strategic opportunity to intentionally align national team selection policies

with domestic football development objectives. By consciously integrating qualified and deserving players from the Ghana Premier League into the Black Stars during our participation in the World Cup 2026, we stand to channel a share of these global solidarity funds directly into our local clubs, many of which continue to grapple with severe financial constraints, infrastructural deficits and limited commercial sponsorship.

Mr Speaker, our local clubs serve as the foundational institutions for football talent development in Ghana. They scout, nurture and refine players from grassroots levels, often with minimal resources and institutional support. It is therefore both logical and just that these clubs should benefit materially when their players are called upon to serve the national interest on the international stage. The deliberate inclusion of locally based players in our national team setup will yield several tangible benefits:

- It will provide direct financial inflows to domestic clubs through FIFA's compensation mechanism;
- It will enhance the financial sustainability of clubs within the Ghana Premier League;
- It will incentivise structured youth development and talent identification programmes across the country;
- It will improve player welfare and professional standards within the local league;

- It will increase the competitiveness, attractiveness and commercial viability of our domestic football competitions; and
- It will ultimately contribute to the long-term sustainability of football development in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, beyond the financial dimension, such an approach will also serve as a strong signal of confidence in the quality of talent within our domestic league. It will provide locally based players with a legitimate pathway to national recognition and inspire emerging footballers to pursue excellence within our local football structure. Furthermore, the increased visibility of local players on the international stage has the potential to attract foreign investment, sponsorship opportunities and talent scouting interests into our domestic league, thereby creating a virtuous cycle of growth and reinvestment.

Mr Speaker, it is important to emphasise that this proposal does not seek to undermine meritocracy in national team selection. Rather, it advocates for a balanced and strategic approach that recognises the dual objectives of achieving competitive success at the international level while simultaneously fostering the development of our domestic football industry. In this regard, I respectfully call upon the Ghana Football Association, the technical leadership of the Black Stars, and all relevant stakeholders within our football governance framework to adopt

a policy direction that affords competitive opportunities to ten (10) qualified locally based players during the course of our World Cup campaign.

Mr Speaker, by leveraging the financial redistribution mechanisms embedded within FIFA's Club Benefits Programme, Ghana can transform national team participation from a purely sporting pursuit into a strategic instrument for domestic football revitalisation and economic empowerment. In doing so, we will not only compete for glory on the world stage but also ensure that the pride of representing our nation translates into measurable growth for the clubs that form the backbone of Ghanaian football.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this Statement.

[Published by order of Mr Speaker.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have exhausted all 13 Statements before us today; therefore, Statement time has ended. Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we want to pray you that, given the mood of the House, we want to do some consideration, especially of the Security Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025. We will take about 10 clauses. But before then, may I pray that we lay the item numbered 10(a).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, moving chronologically from 9 to 10.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, my very bosom Friend failed to engage. He has not engaged, but he wants to have—he has not, if he had, I would not stand here and say he has not engaged. He is even calling my integrity to question.

Mr Speaker, if he wants to lay a Paper, he should engage and the Leader will say that he is a very good person when it comes to engagement. He does not engage. He should learn from my very respected Leader, Hon Mahama Ayariga. This is a Minister who is dealing with recruitment issues. We do not see our constituents being recruited, but he still wants to proceed. There is no security or intelligence on this matter, Mr Speaker.

He has not engaged. Let him engage properly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, at the commencement of public Business—Presentation of Papers. The item numbered 10(a), Minister for Roads and Highways.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Minister just left the Floor. So may I pray that the Deputy Minister for Health does this on his behalf. Mr Speaker, in our Constitution, a Deputy Minister is also defined as a Minister of State. It is true. That is the law. Hon Nitiwul has been a Leader in this House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: May the Paper be laid by the Deputy Minister for Health.

PAPER

By the Deputy Minister for Health (Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah) on behalf of the Minister for Roads and Highways

Budget Performance Report of the Ministry of Roads and Highways for the period January to December 2025.

Referred to the Committee on Roads and Transportation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. Are we taking the item numbered 10 (b)?

Mr Dafeamekpor: No, Mr Speaker. The (b) is not ready.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, any indication?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, that is so. The item numbered 24 — Consideration.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025, at Consideration Stage.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025

[Resumption of Consideration Stage from 03/03/2026]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, can we remind ourselves as to the last clause? We stopped at clause 12. So we are starting with 13.

Clause 13 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 14—Appointment of National Security Coordinator.

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, new clause - amendment proposed - Before clause 14, *insert* the following new: “Establishment of the Office of National Security Coordinator. There is established by this Act the Office of the National Security Coordinator.”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, any proposed amendments before coming to clause 14?

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, amendment proposed - Subclause (1), line 3, *delete* “referred to in paragraph (a) of Section 12”.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr Kofi Amankwa-Manu: Mr Speaker, I have the permission of Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah. So I want to seek your permission to stand in for him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Amankwa-Manu on behalf of Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, amendment proposed - Subclause (1), line 1, *delete*

“195” and *insert* “70”, and in line 3, after “section 12”, *insert* except that the person shall not be a serving member of any security agency.

So the new rendition will read,

“The President shall, in accordance with Article 70 of the Constitution, appoint a National Security Coordinator as of the office of the National Security Coordinator refer to in paragraph A of section 12, except that person shall not be a serving member of a security agency”.

The rationale being that the National Security Coordinator appointed under 195 comes under the Public Services Commission. And so, under the Public Services Commission, retirement age is 60 and all that. So, in a situation where one is appointed under 195, issues on his exiting may come up, but under 70, those issues will be avoided.

4:33 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House.

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, I am opposed to the proposed amendment by Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah. On clause 14, there is a proposed amendment by Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah. He seeks to *delete* “195” and *insert* “70”, and I am saying that I am opposed to the proposed amendment, and these are my reasons.

Mr Speaker, the Act 526, which is now repealed, clearly had the Security Coordinator's appointment effected under Article 195. Again, Act 1030, which replaced Act 526, had the appointment of the Security Coordinator done under Article 195, and it is for a special reason. Under Article 195, the President does the appointment in consultation with the governing board of the service in question. For the avoidance of that, let me read Article 195(1):

“Subject to the provisions of this Constitution, the power to appoint persons to hold or to act in an office in the public services shall vest in the President, acting in accordance with the advice of the governing council of the service concerned, given in consultation with the public services.”

Mr Speaker, because we are talking about the Security Coordinator, it is important that any appointment of a Security Coordinator by the President must be based on the advice of the National Security Council, which is the governing council of the Secretariat, headed by the Coordinator. If we place this responsibility under Article 70, the President would merely be required to act in consultation with the advice of the Council of State. The Council of State is not the National Security Council. The appropriate body to be consulted when it comes to the appointment of the National Security Coordinator is the National Security Council, where we have all the security capos represented, including the President, the Vice President, Minister

for Defence, Minister for the Interior, Minister for Foreign Affairs, Inspector-General of Police, Chief of Defence Staff, Chief of Military Intelligence, and so on and so forth.

So, let us be careful. It is not for nothing that Act 1030 and Act 526 provided for the appointment under Article 195. In any case, this arrangement has not created any mischief.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, the mover of the amendment, let us clarify some issues. Reference was made to Acts 526 and 1030, and the fact that under Article 70, the appointment is in consultation with the Council of State, but it is Article 195 that will enable the consultation to be with the National Security Council. Do you still insist that it should be done under Article 70?

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, it is true that the previous Acts that we have used, we fully relied on Article 195, and it is because controversies have not arisen that is why we think controversies cannot arise. But it is practically impossible for the President to consult the National Security Council for the appointment of the Security Coordinator. It may sound like that, but it is practically impossible; I have never seen any President consult. One of the first people that a President would appoint is the National Security Coordinator. He would first appoint him as an acting Coordinator and later confirm him. It is for good reason that when the President is appointing the Service Chiefs, for example, he consults the Council of

State. He does not consult the Governing Councils or the Ministry; he consults the Council of State. There are good reasons why it is done like that. So, I think that if we deviate from the old practice of using Article 195, where we use the Public Services Commission procedure, and rather go under Article 70(e), it is much better, where the holder of such offices may be —

So, the President can say that he is acting with the Council of State. Article 70 (e) reads:

“the holders of such offices may be prescribed by this Constitution or by any other law not inconsistent with the Constitution.”

The President can appoint somebody if the holder of that kind of office falls under this category. The person knows that since the President is appointing them, when they are leaving, they would go with him. It is not like the old thing. There are people who could take it to court to say that they are not 60 years old—I know some people who took government to court because they were appointed under Article 195 and said they were not 60 years old, so why are they being asked to go home, since they went through the Public Services Commission. They took the government to court and won. One of them is the late Mr Ade Coker, and he won the case. He was a governing Board Chairperson or something like that. So that is why our Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah is saying that, there is nothing offensive if we use Article 70(1)(e) instead of Article 195. So that it becomes more like a political appointment.

It is done in the United States of America (USA), the United Kingdom (UK) and all other jurisdictions; their time is coterminous with the President who has appointed them; any other President can use the same Article 70(1)(e) to appoint another person. Instead of relying on this, somebody will one day take us to court. We are lucky that people have not done it, but one day somebody can actually take us to court and say, they are under Article 179, and if they go through the Public Services Commission and get that job, they will have to stay there until they are 60 years old and cannot be taken off. That is why I am saying that it is for good reasons that the President —
[Interruption]

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, Article 195(1) says:

“Subject to the provisions of this constitution, the power to appoint persons to hold or to act in an office in the public services...”

We are creating the office of the National Security Coordinator. Is it in the public services? We already agreed that we are just creating an office. We did not even want to create a national security service or anything. It is just an office that is being created. So, it is not an ordinary service, such as we have in the Police Service, the Prison Service, the Ghana Health Service, and all the other services; the coordinator does not fall within that category. So, we cannot even, in my opinion, subject him to the Article 195 appointment.

I am minded to find favour with the proposal that, maybe, there is some consultation with the National Security Council, because, technically speaking, he is going to be working for them. So, as a Council, they could be consulted in appointing that person. Do we consult the Police Service Council when we are appointing the IGP? They consult the Council of State, but with the Council, because the alternative proposal is that the consultation should be with the Council, I think that we do not fall under Article 195. But then the question is, is it the best arrangement to say that the Council should be consulted by the President when he is appointing a coordinator?

4:43 p.m.

What has been the prevailing practice? The President appoints. Yes, so he just appoints. Why are we trying to restrict the President's powers of appointment in this regard?

The coordinator is always appointed at the discretion of the President and removed at his discretion. I believe that we should just say the President will appoint, case closed and leave it. It is one of the areas where we should not fetter the powers of the President. That is my proposal.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, if we look at Article 70 of the 1992 Constitution, under which we are seeking to do the appointment of the National Security Coordinator, we would realise that all those listed here are independent in nature, or independent

constitutional bodies. Is the office of the National Security Coordinator also assuming the nature of an independent constitutional body to warrant the appointment under Article 70? We need to take a second look at it. I would want to defer it because in the law, we are talking about the ministerial responsibility, meaning that the office of the National Security Coordinator is not an independent constitutional body. Therefore, if we subject the appointment under Article 70, it is connoting the independent nature of the institution, which by this law, is not the case. So, we need to be careful whether to use Article 195 or Article 70.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I think that you are right. I think we should defer it, but there are two legs to this amendment. If you defer it, then the next time we come, we could look at the other leg. The other leg has to do with whether the person should be a serving officer or not a serving officer. So let us just defer it and consult and then we will come back to it.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, in reality, there is nothing to defer and let me clarify that. Mr Speaker, when you made the point that the offices listed here are independent in nature, you were right. Mention is made of the Commissioner of CHRAJ, Auditor-General, District Assemblies, Common Fund Administrator, Public Services Commission, Lands Commission — So if you now come down to paragraph (e), and what does the paragraph (e) say? It says:

“the holders of such other offices as may be prescribed by this Constitution or by any other law not inconsistent with this...”

Paragraph (e) by virtue of the list provided, can only be in the nature of the offices.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: By the use of *ejusdem generis*, such other offices must also be independent in nature, like Independent Constitutional Bodies. So, are we saying that the National Security Coordinator should also be independent? If you look at it under Article 70 of the 1992 Constitution, they all come under the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies. So, would the National Security Coordinator also come under Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies?

Mr Nitiwul: But Mr Speaker, when the office itself was not created, there was no problem. The President would just appoint a National Security Coordinator who is an officer of the National Security Council. That was how the original Act— So it was easy to go under Article 195 and do it. Today, we are creating an office. The question is, are we creating that office to go through the processes of the Public Services Commission? *[Interruption]* I am coming. No, it has never been the case. They have never gone for interviews, nothing like that.

So that is what I am trying to say.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are right to that extent, because the proposed amendment, as in subclause 1, appears to be very novel.

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, the argument I sought to make in relation to Article 70 (e) is that we cannot interpret Article 70(e) to include the National Security Coordinator, because that office, by its nature, is not meant to be independent. It is not meant to be independent. Who is the chairperson of the National Security Council? It is the President. And so, a coordinator, who merely coordinates the activities of the Security and Intelligence Agencies, is answerable to the President. Same cannot be said about the Auditor-General or the Commissioner of CHRAJ, or the Lands Commission boss. That is why I am saying that, in reality, there is nothing to defer here. This position is the same. It has not changed. Under Act 526, clearly, the appointment was done by the President in consultation with the Council and the Council— *[Interruption]*—

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, there are some things we cannot say publicly. That is why I agreed with you that we should defer it, consult among ourselves. We can divulge information to you and you look at it and think whether you still want to hold your position or not. I keep saying that, so just listen to Mr Speaker. There are some things, Mr Speaker, I will not say it publicly here. The Hon Leader knows, but he will not say it. He knows, all of us know here, we will not say it publicly. That is why we want to avoid that particular situation, because there

are some things that are happening that we think that we should avoid. That is why I agree with you that we should defer it, and then we consult. When we all sit together as MPs, we will see whether we should proceed like that, or we should stop. It is in your interest.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairperson, can we hear from you?

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, we would like to defer this particular amendment proposed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, that is good because I am also aware of certain problems. When the Ministry was created, the fight between the Minister and then the National Security Coordinator — In view of Article 83 of the Constitution, the President is the Chairperson of the Council and every other person is under the President. I wonder if we can appoint a National Security Coordinator as an independent office under Article 70 of the 1992 Constitution. That may be a bit problematic.

Mr Amankwa-Manu Yes, Mr Speaker, you are right. But besides what you just mentioned, there are other things we have to look into. That is why, upon your advice, I agree with the Chairperson that we defer and do further consultation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Consideration of clause 14 is deferred, particularly owing to Amendment III.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, *insert* the following new subclause:

“(#) A person shall not be appointed as the National Security Co-ordinator unless that person possesses not less than ten years’ relevant professional experience.”

4:53 p.m.

The grounds for this amendment basically is that we want the office to carry with it the weight of professionalism and experience. We know how political power can be exercised to serve a certain political convenience. We do not want that to get into our national security architecture, where a person, by virtue of his or her industry in a party’s rise to power, would want to use certain closeness with the President to say, this is what they want, then the person will be given such an appointment when no such experience has been brought on board.

Mr Speaker, I believe that in any serious establishment, this minimum qualification of 10 years would be in place and proper. In that the person would have gone through the mill in his chosen profession, developed the resilience, the necessary experience and ability to manage situations such that when given that office, we are sure that the person would know what is expected of him. I believe that that 10 years of experience, at least, is a good threshold for any senior management position.

Else, Mr Speaker, we may be throwing this position out to anybody. A National Security Coordinator cannot just be anybody. If we push the argument for the person to have that minimum experience, upon entering there, he earns even the respect of the officers who serve under him.

If we look at the current National Security Coordinator, although he is a Commissioner of Police (COP), if we look at his background, he is a lawyer, he served in the Police Service for over 15 years and he commands that respect among the officers who serve under him. Although somebody would argue that being a COP, there is an Inspector-General of Police (IGP) who is above him. But, Mr Speaker, that is inconsequential to the extent that, per his curriculum vitae (CV), the necessary record is there to prove that he has that public service experience.

The situation would have been different if the person had just two years or three years of post-qualification experience. There would have been an uproar, but that uproar would have led to nothing because that is the pleasure of the President. We do not want situations where the National Security Coordinator would be an officer of convenience. The argument here is that even if there would be some level of convenience, it must be backed with some substance because the office must not be toyed with.

We are dealing with state security, the very survival of our democracy and matters that would even connect to our international security and foreign

relations. These are the underlying reasons for my proposal for us to introduce this minimum threshold by way of post-qualification experience. Mr Speaker, I so submit.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is now for the consideration of the House. Before opening the floor, Minority Leader, your proposed amendment appears to be nebulous. Nebulous in the sense that if you say relevant professional experience, who determines the relevant professional experience? Relevant professional experience in what? So, if somebody has spent 10 years in full security service, which is also of national security, is the person qualified?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, it would have been better if you had asked me to clarify. If you use the language nebulous to describe what I propose, I have an issue with it, but I can let it slide.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The word 'nebulous' is not offensive.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I did not say it is offensive. I did not use the word 'offensive'. I said I have a difficulty with your description of my proposal as being nebulous. In your context, you said I have said 'relevant professional experience'. What I am basically saying is that whatever the person is bringing on board — that is why in my argument, I used post-qualification experience.

National security is at large. I am not arguing that the person should have 10

years of security experience. No. The person can be of any background. All I am saying is that whatever profession the person is practising to qualify to this position, the person should at least demonstrate that they have, at least, 10 years post-qualification experience.

Mr Speaker, determining it is very simple. People put their CV on board and if I say 10 years' experience as a lawyer, we can only calculate from the day I was called to the bar and my various experience in practice. If the person is a chartered accountant and says 10 years, we will look at the CV and what the person brings on board. If the person is a public servant, we can calculate from the day he entered public service.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me put it this way so that you will understand me.

All the categories that you are mentioning are professional in nature. In this case, you are not talking about 10 years working experience; you are talking about 10 years professional experience. So, if you say a lawyer or a chartered accountant, it is easy to determine.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Well, Mr Speaker, I think to that extent, let me agree with you and rather amend it from the professional experience to working experience. If we are talking about a minimum of 10 years working experience — but the language has always been professional experience. But if for this legislation, it is your

thinking that making it working experience of 10 years minimum would meet the threshold instead of saying professional experience, Mr Speaker, it is one and the same. It is just a matter of language use. I would not mind to say so.

But I think the mainstay of the argument here is that a person occupying that high office should not be that person who is merely appointed for the convenience of it. As much as possible, we are trying to ensure professionalism in the institutional pillars that are helping grow our democracy. Mr Speaker, if you may recall, there were earlier concerns about how District Security Coordinators and Regional Security Coordinators are appointed. There is no regard to experience or background. Most of the Regional Security Coordinators are party apparatchiks and we know the kind of problems they give to our National Security.

About a month ago, I gave my own experience. When my pickup was coming from Winneba, the Regional Security Coordinator had instructed the pickup to be arrested. He said it was for national security reasons. I had to call the boss because he said his boss had instructed him. When I called, he said nobody had sent him. So, they had to order him to take the pickup back to Winneba. He did not have any reason. He said they were just doing a check. These were some party matters that I do not want to talk about here and would want to use "I know where the power lies" or "I wield some powers".

So, Mr Speaker, what I am basically saying is that even if we want to meet a certain partisan convenience, the person should also have that added professionalism and experience

5:03 p.m.

That would give some weight, so the person entering that office will carry some merit and respect because there are career officers who are professionals. No President would want to appoint anybody to that office as the head of our security and intelligence agencies, and the person does not wield or command any respect.

Mr Speaker, I just want to make this argument for the record.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think he just answered himself. I listened to him, and in the end, he landed where I wanted him to land, which is that the President would not just appoint anyone as his National Security Coordinator. That is why we should not attempt to fetter the President, because when we make such provisions, we underrate the intelligence of a president. A president knows what kind of person he should appoint as his National Security Coordinator. So, let us leave it to the President. Let him decide who he wants and what level of skills the person has.

In a world where cybersecurity becomes the main issue, we may have a young person who does not have 10 years of professional experience, but is a genius in cybersecurity, and the President may feel that this is the person

who can do the job. So, if we start imposing age or years rigidities into appointments—there are many who are even advocating that we should reduce the number of years that somebody is qualified to be a presidential candidate. It is even in some recommendations that may come to this House. Now, even a Member of Parliament, people say we should reduce it to 18 years. But when we start saying that the person must have 10 years of experience, then indirectly, we are imposing age restrictions. When is the person going to finish university? When is he going to start that professional career and ultimately have 10 years of experience? We are pushing the age bracket to at least 45 or 50 years, when a 30-year-old might be qualified for the job. But it is all something that I think is summed up in his own conclusion that a president will not just appoint anyone as his Coordinator. So many factors are considered: one, professional skills; two, trust because the role that person will be playing will be very sensitive; unless the President actually trusts that person, it will be difficult. We have seen the fate of security coordinators when their President stops trusting them. When their President stops trusting them, that is the end of their job.

So, I think we should leave it this way and allow the President to decide who he wants to appoint as his coordinator.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I agree with him on some aspects of his submissions, but he does not address the mainstay of my argument regarding the proposed amendment. But Mr Speaker,

Hansard has already captured me. I do not need to belabour the point. Mr Speaker may have to put the question for the House to decide.

Mr Dafeamekpor: The Minority Leader is now asking us to define what is relevant professional experience. It may become a subject of another litigation; ‘working’ needs to still be interpreted. What does relevant working experience mean? Mr Speaker, we urge him to withdraw, so we can—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I do not find a compelling argument from the other Side to warrant a withdrawal of my Motion. I still hold the view that, as important as that office is, some threshold must be introduced to guide the President. Mr Speaker, an unchecked power can be abused. It is the reason why consistently when we have own laws, we introduce some age limitation, and some qualifications. We can also have a genius who is so smart and intelligent that even at 25 years old, he can become president. But the 1992 Constitution says a minimum of 40 years. We can have a smart person who, even at age 12, can do things that 25-year-olds do, but the 1992 Constitution says 21 years qualifies one to be a Member of Parliament.

So, Mr Speaker, that argument does not find favour with me, respectfully, to say that in this ICT age, we can have a genius who is so smart in Artificial Intelligence (AI) or digital intelligence, and the President may want to keep him there. Yes, but the President would also

have to be guided, apart from trust, by the nature of the Office. Mr Speaker, why is that we do not just appoint anybody as a Minister for Foreign Affairs? Why is it that in all the United Nations (UN) or diplomatic appointments, when it gets to appointing somebody as Ghana’s representative to the UN in Geneva, we are careful who goes to Geneva as our representative, and not just about somebody who represents us in a country as our ambassador. So, Mr Speaker, we are careful depending on which portfolio we are giving to whom. I believe that introducing this minimum qualification suffices in the circumstances, but let us leave it to the Floor to decide. I am unable to withdraw. I thank you, sir.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have been living with Act (526), and then we move to Act (1030), but these requirements are not part of our laws. We need to understand. Have the current positions brought about any problems that will necessitate the amendment? Well, you do not intend to answer my question, but you want me to put the question on your proposed amendment. I will do so.

Question put and amendment negatived.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will not put a question on the entire clause 14, because some aspects have been deferred. We then move to clause 15.

Clause 15 — Functions of the National Security Co-ordinator

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, before the Chairperson moves the next amendment, I believe that this proposal, which got defeated by the House, is one that goes to the heart of policy. It is the reason I want to encourage the Majority Leader to ensure that the sector Minister is present in the next Consideration. Mr Speaker, when we were doing the Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025, in most cases, we did not find the Attorney-General here.

5:13 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I do not want us to encourage our ministers to stay out of this Chamber when their Bills are being taken. They must find time to be with us, especially on policy. What I just proposed goes to the heart of policy. If the Minister were to be here, he would have made the matter easier. I know that there are times that the Minister can be out of this House, so that we do it on his behalf. But where is the Deputy Minister? If an emergency has taken the Minister out of the Chamber, at least the Deputy Minister should be here.

So, Mr Speaker, I will not belabour the point, but I think it is important that our Ministers are made to understand that once they introduce a public Business into this House, they must find time out of their busy schedule to be here so they can honour industry.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, unfortunately the Minority Leader just joined. **[Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** I was watching proceedings from my office] If he was watching, he would have known

that the Hon Minister for the Interior, responsible for National Security, was right here. **[Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Yes, but he left] In fact, he should know that today is Monday. And we are doing this because of his position that it ought to be done. But there is an emergency, and I am sure it is all over the news. So, it took him off the Floor, the Minister and his Deputy. So, they are attending to that matter. And so, *[Interruption]*—Yes, he has been here all day. Hon Shaib is aware. He has been manning the Floor. So, when the Minority Leader is up and going after the Ministers of State, it is not fair. It is wrong because the Hon Minority Leader ought to have known that the man was here. It was a helicopter crash just a while ago that took him to see to it. He knows. So, he should not go after him unnecessarily.

Mr Speaker, on that note, let us make progress with the Consideration.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, because records have captured him, it is important that I respond.

Mr Speaker, this blackmail will not have any impact on me. The point is that Ministers would have to be present. If there are exceptional circumstances, so be it, but the Deputy Minister must be here. It is not about going after the Minister. In any event, is there anything wrong with the Minority going after Ministers? There is no problem. It is part of politics, to go after them so that they will sit up. That is our job. Going after them is no problem, and we will not shy away from it. If we go after them, they

will sit up and do their work well. So, there is no problem. That is why we are here. We are here to go after them, including the Majority Chief Whip so, he does his work well and ensure the welfare of this House. If we do not go after him as Majority Chief Whip, this House will not enjoy the peace and comfort. So, I will go after him. **[Hon Darko: He should look at his back]—**

He should look at his back, so many empty seats. If I do not go after him, he would not call a Caucus meeting and make his Members happy. A lot of them are not happy. He would not call for a Caucus meeting and ginger them up. So, I must go after him so that the Majority Leader will not be too comfortable. He must not be sitting in this Chamber but going to the Presidency and ensure the happiness of the House. So, Mr Speaker, I am not shying away. I will go after all of them. This House can know its peace. Members are not properly constituted. If he does not know, I am telling him. **[Some Hon Members: Leader ooo! Leader!] Look at his Members. They are happy. Are you happy? Mr Speaker, they are very happy. They are happy I am talking for them. Majority Chief Whip, what is okay? If I do that, he will call for a Caucus meeting. The Ministers will come here. They will be busy picking phone calls. But when we go after them, they will take care of Members of Parliament. Make sure that there are projects in our constituencies, not personal matters.**

Mr Speaker, I will clarify. But Hon Sam George should know. He has been a Backbencher, so he knows the interests

of Members of Parliament, that there are projects in their constituencies, and if we do not make them sit up, he would ignore them. *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we should be careful the kind of injury that we inflict on ourselves as Members of Parliament. If you look at Standing Order 156 to 179, which deals with Consideration of a Bill, nowhere is reference made to the Minister. Now, if you also look at Article 93(2), it says:

“Subject to the provisions of this Constitution, the legislative power of Ghana shall be vested in Parliament and shall be exercised in accordance with this Constitution”.

Not exercised in accordance with the presence of any Minister. So, why are we always doing this to ourselves, that because the sector Minister is not available, we cannot consider a Bill?

There is also an understanding that we can make the law the way we want it to be. But as for policy, we do not have the authority to change it. So, to say that what you are proposing is a matter of policy, and that the Minister would have to be here, cannot, with all due respect, be the correct position of what we should be doing. We are to consider the law so, to say that you are proposing a policy at a stage where we are doing a consideration of a Bill, for me, with all due respect, this cannot be the correct position.

So, let us make progress to clause 15. Chairperson of the Committee, you may move amendment (v).

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, Amendment proposed - Paragraph (d), line 2, before

“intelligence”, insert “security and”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any further amendment? In the absence of any further amendment, I will put a question.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairperson of the Committee, amendment (vi)?

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, we wish to abandon this proposal for the appointment of a Deputy National Security Coordinator, so that it is left to the discretion of the appointing authority, as opposed to legislating it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. It is for the consideration of the House. The amendment is accordingly abandoned.

I will then put the question on the entire clause 15.

Clause 15, as amended, ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 16 — Staff of the Office of the National Security Coordinator.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairperson of the Committee.

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, amendment proposed—Subclause (1), line 1, *delete*

“clause (1) of”, and in line 2, after “appoint” *delete* “any”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the proposal is for the consideration of the House. I will put the question.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, given that this particular clause is aligned to the issue raised in clause 14, which is:

“The President may in accordance with clause 2 of article 195 of the Constitution, delegate the power of appointment under this section”

I think we would like to stand this down until we have actually discussed clause 14 in detail.

5:23 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. It is understandable. Then I will also defer the entire clause 16 as well. Please move the amendment in (ix).

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, transpose clauses 12 and 13 before clause 17 as follows:

“Composition of Intelligence agencies

#. The intelligence agencies in this Act comprise the

- (a) internal intelligence agency existing immediately before the coming into force of this Act and known as the National Intelligence Bureau, now referred to as the Bureau of National Intelligence; and
- (b) external intelligence agency existing immediately before the coming into force of this Act and known as the Research Department.

Governing body of the intelligence agencies

#. The governing body of the intelligence agencies is the National Security Council.”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, any further amendment?

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 17 — Functions of internal and external intelligence agencies

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This one is standing in the name of Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah.

Mr Kofi Amankwa-Manu: Mr Speaker I crave your indulgence to stand in for the Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Amankwa-Manu on behalf of Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, clause 17 as captured in the Bill. We have two agencies: the NIB responsible for the internal collating of intelligence and analysing same and then we have the research department which is responsible for external, but if you look at clause 17 as captured, it is all boxed in one and so it is difficult to really distinguish which agency is responsible for either the internal or the external and so we propose that we look at what we have under Act 1030 where we have specific functions under each of the agencies that is NIB and Research department. Thank You, Mr Speaker.

Amendment proposed – Delete and insert the following:

Functions of the national security intelligence agencies

17. (1) The Internal Intelligence Agency shall

- (a) brief the President, the National Security Council and any other relevant stakeholder on intelligence gathered internally, relevant to the national security interests of the country;
- (b) monitor, collect, analyse, evaluate, retain and disseminate in an appropriate manner information and intelligence gathered internally and perform intelligence operations;

(c) be responsible for

- (i) counter intelligence, and activities for the internal security and stability of the country; and
- (ii) intelligence gathered internally in order to prevent and counter violent extremism, including terrorism, in the country;
- (d) provide intelligence to aid the formulation of Government policy and programmes;
- (e) provide Government with feedback from the populace;
- (f) gather intelligence to counter threats from organised crime and any other form of criminal activity;
- (g) conduct investigations in collaboration with the relevant security agencies into serious offences and matters of national importance;
- (h) support the provision of security protection for
 - (i) the Presidency;
 - (ii) visiting diplomats and other persons with diplomatic immunity; and
 - (iii) designated public officials; and
 - (iv) perform any other function for intelligence purposes as

directed by the Council or the Minister.

(2) The External Intelligence Agency shall

- (a) brief the President, the National Security Council and any other relevant stakeholder on intelligence gathered externally, relevant to the national security interests of the country;
- (b) monitor, collect, analyse, evaluate, retain and disseminate in an appropriate manner information and intelligence gathered externally and perform intelligence operations;
- (c) collect intelligence on economic issues and any other issue of strategic relevance to national development;
- (d) provide intelligence from external sources in order to prevent and counter violent extremism, including terrorism, in the country;
- (e) engage in counter intelligence and activities to advance the national interest at the international level;
- (f) conduct due diligence on foreign entities and high-profile personalities including Ambassadors designate or High Commissioners designate and profile persons of interest;

- (g) liaise with foreign intelligence services for the purpose of intelligence sharing and the provision of opportunities for technical assistance and training;
- (h) provide external intelligence insights to aid in the formulation of foreign policy and assist the decision-making process of Government on foreign engagements;
- (i) provide intelligence to aid in combatting all forms of criminal activity; and
- (j) perform any other function for intelligence purposes as directed by the Council or the Minister.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, it is for the consideration of the House.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, what they have done is to really replicate the functions from Act 1030 into this one by delineating those rules as what is performed by the internal intelligence agencies vis-a-vis the functions meant for the external intelligence agencies, so it enhances the legislation in my view, so I do not think it is fatal. We can take it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairperson of the Committee

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, I think that perhaps being too detailed with regards to the internal and external agencies might be in a way limiting

whereas if we leave the broad-based functions, it gives a little bit more room because sometimes there is a bit of a crossover between the two and to delineate it exactly may create a bit of an issue I think if we actually specify it into law. The Securities and Intelligence Act, 1996 (Act 526) was a bit broad and it put the two together. The Bill that came to the Committee blended the two and expanded slightly. I am not quite sure whether we really want to separate the two as is in Act 1030 or to leave it more broad-based as it is.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, first of all in practical terms the way they work, it is important that the Bill specifies the roles for each of them. We all know where the external intelligence agency operates. It is not for me to say it here. There is a reason why it operates there even though—it is under this particular agency, National Security Council but it operates under a certain ministry for obvious reasons and the internal agency operates within Ghana and we all know where it operates with distinct heads and functions and it is for that reason that under Act 1030 we needed to specify just like the Bureau of Communication Authority, that this is what both the internal and external agencies are supposed to do. There is nothing that bars them from operating if they need to communicate and operate with each other. The difficulty is that if we oversimplify it this way, there will be a big problem because they will clash and will not know their defined roles and I can tell you that when they go and want to perform their defined roles, they will have problems. So, if you ask them in

practical terms, which one they will prefer, they will tell you that when their roles were specified, it was very easy for them to really work. So, if you go to the BNI or NIB, the agency heads knew what they were supposed to do. If you go to research, the Research Department knows what they are supposed to do. If you go to the communication one, they also know what they are supposed to do but there is nothing wrong if they interact which they always do because they are security agencies. The Police Intelligence know that this is what they are supposed to do and their roles are specified, same as the Defence Intelligence. So, I think that we should allow the amendment to go through. The Chairperson should support this amendment. It even enhances the Bill itself so that clearly each of the agencies know specifically what they are supposed to do and what they need to do. With the way it is put, if you are not careful you will think they are supposed to do the same work but they perform totally different roles by nature of what they do and where they are placed and for that reason, I would say that we should support the amendment and allow us to take what is in Act 1030 and put it here. Otherwise, we would come back again to do amendment because when they start working there will be duplication of functions then they will start having problems as to what each agency is supposed to do. Two, if we do not have a very co-operating Minister for Foreign Affairs, one would have a problem if we want to use this—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you mentioned aspects of Act

1030, guide as from the perspective of the Act 1030 because I see section 14 of Act 1030: functions of the National Security Intelligence Agency, they have not divided it into internal and external.

Mr Amankwa-Manu: Mr Speaker, so here we have the functions of the Internal Intelligence Agency which consists of briefing the President—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which clause?

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, so section 14(1) of Act 1030 specifically talks about the Internal Intelligence Agency and states its functions and when you come down to section 14(2), it talks about the External Intelligence Agency and the functions are spelt out as well. Mr Speaker, I think this approach is better. Once there is that distinction between internal and external, the functions cannot be the same and in drafting, we need to be very specific. Let us be informed as to what constitutes the functions of the Internal Security Agency vis-a-vis the specific functions of the External Intelligence Agency in order to avoid conflict.

Mr Samuel Nartey George: Thank you, Mr Speaker. On the surface of it and listening to the former Minister for Defence and the Majority Chief Whip,

5:33 p.m.

The delineation of the roles to avoid a possible turf war. However, I have a bit of a reservation when it comes to the extent of delineation that we see in the

proposal. For example, do we need to put in legislation that our external intelligence agency will conduct due diligence on foreign entities and high-profile personalities?

I think that some of the details in here are already intrinsic in their role. So even if we will delineate it, specifying and going into the minutiae of their daily operations in legislation is where I am a bit uncomfortable. I think that if it is possible, the delineation is good, but let us find a way of keeping it within certain broad strokes that still leave a certain room for manoeuvrability for the heads of agencies.

And the Chairperson just passed a comment here, the threat profile may change in another two years, yet we have spelt out specific roles and things that internal and external intelligence must do. Would we then come back to this House to redefine the threat profile every time it changes. So I think we can do the delineation, but let us not go into too much of the details. So if it is possible for the Committee to go back and look at this and find a middle ground, if the Minister and Hon Kojo could have that conversation, to find a middle ground, I think that would do us good.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, in the circumstances, I intend to defer Clause 17.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I will not argue with you, but just to add that, for some reason, I was not at the winnowing or consultation stage, always add the clause “any other duty assigned by the

head” for security matters. Always make sure that that clause is added. Is it there already? Good. So once there is a new threat, they will assign them. But I say that there are some things that, if we do not make them explicit, they will not do it. There were good reasons why this particular clause, which he mentioned, was put inside. Take it from me. There were good reasons. Otherwise, they will not do it. And I will leave it there.

They will go after the Minister for reporting on you sitting here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. Any indication?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the prayer is that we do 10 clauses. So once we stand this down, we take 18, 19, and we close at 20.

Clause 18 — Appointment of Directors-General

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, amendment proposed – subclause (1), *delete* and *insert* as follows: “The President shall, in accordance with article 195 of the Constitution, appoint a Director-General as head of each of the intelligence agencies.”

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, we take it to be consequential?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Yes, the argument remains the same.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Should I still put a question?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Yes, I am saying the argument remains the same. So you put a question, just for the record.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that was the view that once we put a question and it was defeated, we do not repeat it. But if the sense of the House is that I should repeat the question, I have no option.

So I will put a question on the proposed amendment by Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin.

Question put and amendment negative.

Clause 18 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, normally, when you are putting a question, you put the question so directly. On this occasion, you deliberately mentioned my name and then emphasised it to draw attention to the people.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Osahen Afenyo-Markin, by practice, mostly, the amendments are in the name of the Chairperson of the Committee. But when there is an amendment standing in the name of an individual Member of Parliament, you would have to emphasise that this is an amendment in favour of this Member of Parliament before you put the question—

Oh, you said I am not good? Well, for all you know, I voted for you. Have you forgotten I have a voting right? But on this occasion, when it is a voice vote, how am I going to vote? Am I also going to shout?

Clause 19— Functions of Directors-General.

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, amendment proposed, paragraph (c) line 1, after “political”, insert “party”.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, amendment proposed – After paragraph (e), *insert* the following new subclause: “(f) issue and enforce a code of conduct on political neutrality and professional ethics” I so move.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. I did not see you on your feet early.

5:43 p.m.

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader has not in any way justified why there is the need for us to insert the proposed amendment. After clause 19(e); there has to be some justification. We are talking about the enforcement of a code of conduct on political neutrality and professional ethics.

Mr Speaker, first of all, how can an appointee of the President be the one to enforce political neutrality? How? I do not see how that is practicable.

So, let the Minority Leader explain why he thinks it is the responsibility of the Directors-General to perform the function he wants to ascribe to them, then we can proceed from there.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, clause 19 deals with the functions of the Director-General. Clause 19 (a) talks about the efficient and responsible performance of the functions of internal and external agencies, of which the Director-General is the head.

Mr Speaker, (b) talks about controlling and administering. Even the (c), there is “...political neutrality of the internal or external intelligence agencies of which the Director-General is the head”; it is there in the (c). Then the (d) talks about the internal grievance procedure.

So, Mr Speaker, these are administrative functions. What I am adding is the professional ethics and the political neutrality. Because the political neutrality is mentioned, I can abandon the political neutrality because it is already there, and then deal with the professional ethics.

Mr Speaker, is it not right that as part of the functions for the Director-General of a unit, under the national security architecture to ensure that officers who work under them, act within the scope of professional ethics and the etiquette of the profession, that they should be left ajar?

Mr Speaker, it is already in there, and it is supposed to guide—*[Interruption]*—

No. I am saying that because the professional neutrality is already there in clause 19 (c), I am ready to abandon the political neutrality.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Member can rise for the records and speak for the amendment so that—and I am okay, I am not opposed to him further amending my amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, is clause 19 (c) not addressing your concern?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: That is why we are amending. We are agreeing to take away the “political neutrality” and then focus on “professional ethics”.

Mr Speaker, you hear him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon James Agalga.

Mr Agalga: So, Mr Speaker, the clarification makes it imperative for me to suggest that the Minority Leader *delete* from his proposed amendment the phrase, “political neutrality”, since that is already catered for in clause 19 (c), so that we now have “issue and enforce a code of conduct on professional ethics”, which is all right.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, would it not be better if you say “shall pursue and ensure political neutrality and professional ethics of the internal or external intelligence agencies of which the Director-General is the head”? So, you amend clause 19 (c) to introduce “professional ethics”.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I do not mind.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, then, adopt the proposed amendment, and let us make progress.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, without more, I adopt the rendition as provided by you, which says that (c)—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are causing trouble for me. I am not supposed to provide rendition.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, that is fine. So, clause 19 (c) be further amended to read “shall pursue and ensure political party neutrality and professional ethics of the internal or external intelligence agencies of which the Director-General is the head.”

Mr Speaker, I so move.

Question put and amendment agreed to

Clause 19 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 20 — Appointments of other Staff and Employees of Internal and External Intelligence Agencies.

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, the amendment proposed is for subclause (1), line 1, *delete* “clause 1 of” and in line 2, *delete* “any”.

So, the new rendition would be “The President shall, in accordance with Article 195 of the Constitution, appoint other staff and employees required for

the effective performance of the functions of the internal and external agencies.”

I so move.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have a problem with that rendition. I do not want to proceed on any presumption. Normally, when we couch such phrases, we make reference to other public services, or the President appointing other persons from the Public Service. Like when the Office of the Special Prosecutor (OSP) was established, some officers from Customs, from the National Intelligence Bureau (NIB) itself, were appointed. Some police officers were appointed, but, Mr Speaker, this rendition does not address that. If we say “the President shall appoint other staff and employees required...”, “other staff from where?”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, take a look at clause 20 (3).

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Clause 20 (3) says, “Other public officers may be seconded or transferred to any of the internal and external intelligence agencies”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, your question is, these other staff are from where?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Yes, but, Mr Speaker, it does not answer my question. The clause 20 (3) deals with secondment. Mr Speaker, secondment is

different from appointment. I will submit respectfully.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but in all the laws that we have passed, do we indicate the place of where the people are taken from?

5:53 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No, Mr Speaker, we are talking about two things in one. First, we are talking about appointment for that office, which perhaps may emanate from an advertisement, interview, leading to an eventual appointment. Then the President is given that discretion to appoint other staff from within the Public Service. But I am saying that the way the phrase is, it does not connect it to Public Service. Mr Speaker, let us look at article 195.

Mr Speaker, article 195 talks about the power to appoint and the necessary constitutional imperative. But, Mr Speaker, it does not address the missing language here. Perhaps to—other public office. Mr Speaker, let me read it again so that I fill it in. Because in (3), it has been properly captured under secondment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, then let me put the question on the Chairperson's amendment so that we can propose an amendment.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, to what?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: To what you are saying, so that it can be clear.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I move that line two of clause one, we insert “from the Public Service” after “employees”. Mr Speaker, the new rendition shall read—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, do you not think that your amendment will be too dangerous? Too dangerous in the sense that it will mean that if the person is not already in the Public Service, he cannot be appointed as “any other staff”.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, respectfully, just bear with me. You will get to understand.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I am trying to bear with you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, whenever we have used the word “other staff”, reference has been made to Public Service. Mr Speaker, you can check with all the laws.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is that how it is?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: All the laws where we have made provision for appointment of other staff— Mr Speaker, if you do not specify, then where are you going to bring the other staff? Why is it that in the 20 (3)—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Director General is specifically appointed. Now, the clause 20 is saying that there may be the need to appoint other staff of that department. So, the other staff may be appointed in accordance with the Public Service Act, 1994 (Act 482), but the people need not be public servants. If you are talking about already public servants, then you are talking about secondment, and the secondment is taken care of by 20(3). Those already in public service, they will go on secondment. But the appointment of the other staff, the other staff need not necessarily be those who are already working in public service.

Hon Members, I was on the floor before giving the floor to the Minority Leader. If you look at Act 526 and Act 1030, specifically Act 1030, it is section 17. It says:

“the President shall, in accordance with article 195 of the Constitution, appoint any other staff and employee required for the efficient and effective performance of the functions of the intelligence agencies.”

It is rather subsection 2 that says that: “other public officers may be seconded or transferred to any other intelligence agency”.

So, it is like it is a repetition of what is in Act 1030.

I do not know any other Bill that specifies where other staff should be appointed from. Let me hear the Majority Leader, then I can come to you.

Mr Ayariga: Minority Leader, I think there is absolutely nothing wrong. There is nothing wrong with this.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, when the Majority Leader does some of these things, and I do him small, then he would say, I have done something. Put the microphone off so that we solve the problem. He deliberately kept the mic on. Mr Speaker, I rest my case.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. We move to Proposed Amendment XVII. Chairperson of the Committee.

Dr Agyeman-Rawlings: Mr Speaker, I beg to move: Subclause (2), delete.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The reason is that within article 195, article 195 (2) already has taken care of that.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 20 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we had agreed that we will end up at clause 20. Mr Speaker, it has been a long day. You know.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, I have the energy to continue. Let us end it up at clause 30? The proposal is to end it up at clause 30.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, very well.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I realise that you are rather tired. You could not even respond to questions put. So, say so. Do not use me as an excuse.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, so it is, clause 30, and the Minority Leader is in agreement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Clause 21 — Investigation of Complaints.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Leadership engaged extensively, and also gauged the mood of the House.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Except that your engagements are always minus me.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, that is so. That was a mistake we made. Mr Speaker, that was a great error on the face of the record.

6:03 p.m.

So, Mr Speaker, we plead with you that you bear with us. We should have engaged you for your consent that we were ending at Clause 20, so that some other parliamentary duties are discharged outside of this Chamber. Mr Speaker, please bear with us.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it is 6:07 p.m. We started around 12 noon.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have done more than five hours.

Mr Dafeamekpor: So, we are entirely in your hands.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order 56 (2). Yes?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, when it comes to the Rules, we know how faithfully you apply the rules. This is the people's Chamber, so we know sometimes you are flexible. We on this Side of the House would want to thank you. You have been alone in the Chair, guiding this whole process, so we want to thank you.

Mr Speaker, as we leave this Chamber this evening with the expectation of God granting us life for tomorrow, we want to present something through the Majority Chief Whip to Government.

[The Minority Leader raises a petition]

Students on scholarship at Birmingham University UK, have not had their fees paid and the immigration authorities in the United Kingdom (UK) are threatening to deport them. They have been given one week to come back home. We would want to plead with him that if he can draw the attention of Ghana Scholarship Secretariat to remit their fees because the UK government has some strict procedure. They have been crying and sent a petition to us and I will give you a copy.

Mr Speaker, the second thing has to do with the recruitment exercise. We have seen a statement issued by the Minister of State in charge of Government Communications talking about an increase in the number from 5,000 to 10,000 every year. That does not address the core concerns. We want the Majority Chief Whip — he gave his word last week that our respected Colleague, the Minister for the Interior, will come and brief this House.

We do not want this to be treated the way they treated the cocoa haircut where the Minister for Finance announced a haircut at his Ministry. The people's representatives must be properly briefed, especially when this recruitment has to do with our own constituents. The Minister of State in charge of Government Communications, a spokesperson to the President is himself a Member of Parliament. I watched his interview where he spoke about his own frustration that there was a time that he had to take GH¢500 from his wife to pay for bills because they had taken all his money.

Mr Speaker, I talked about my experience once where there was no fuel in my car from Winneba to Accra because I had shared everything and my driver told me that there was no fuel in the car but my pocket was empty. We should not take this recruitment thing for granted. It is not enough to have meetings at Jubilee House. The Minister must brief us. The concerns are so that —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, kindly conclude.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am concluding. The Government Chief Whip gave his word. The issues have not been addressed. 200,000 people have been asked to go and do medicals, paying GH¢1,600 per medical test. Even the new communication says it has been increased to 10,000 people, which means that even if it is 20 per cent — 40,000 for four years, meaning every year it will be 10,000 new recruits. I have read it. I have read the full statement. Let us get serious.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You see —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I will conclude, but please let me land.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But hear me out. I thought you wanted to speak on the Bill. The Mace is still tilted.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well, Mr Speaker, I agree with you. You are a man of procedure. The Mace should be straightened, so that I can finish.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have come to the end of the Consideration Stage of the Securities and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025.

So, Minority Leader, in conclusion?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, my humble plea is that the Government Chief Whip must be a man of his words. We know him to be a man of his words. He gave his word to this House that our respected Colleague, the

Minister for the Interior, with additional responsibility on national security matters, will come and brief this House. This afternoon, we have seen a statement issued by the Minister of State in charge of Government Communications talking about a meeting at Jubilee House where Mr President directed that the recruitment threshold should be increased to 40,000 for four years, meaning each year is 10,000.

Now, Mr Speaker, what that means is that the 200,000 people that the Minister has announced that have qualified for medicals, even if 20 per cent should pass medicals, we would have had 180,000 who would have paid GHC1,600.

Mr Dafeamekpor: 105,000.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: 105,000. Very well, Mr Speaker, I stand corrected. So even if 20 per cent of the 105,000 who have qualified for medicals should pass, it means that we would have 80 —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, in view of the fact that you have made this submission on the Floor today, I am not comfortable with you using the platform to rehash it.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am not rehashing it. It is because there is an intervening matter. There is a statement that has just been issued. But I rest my case, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, we have indulged you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I will not press it, so let me conclude. The Majority Chief Whip must get the Minister to come and brief the House. The concerns are still there. I rest my case. Thank you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, number one, the petition supposedly from the students in Birmingham University, the Minority Leader know the rules. He knows how petitions are submitted. Once he engages the House, we will deal with it.

Number two, let me praise the President for being a listening man, who in view of the huge numbers, has directed that the intake be doubled. At least it is such a huge comfort for the teeming young Ghanaian men and women who are desirous of serving in uniform. That is how a listening Government operates.

So, Mr Speaker, we want to thank the President for making that decision.

6:13 p.m.

I believe that — *[Interruption]* —

The decision is that instead of recruiting 5,000 for this year, 10,000 or more will be recruited. The financial clearance—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we need to call it a day, so let us listen to each other.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we will praise the President. As the elected

representatives of the people, this House is grateful to His Excellency the President for increasing the intake for last year. He has also increased the intake for this year and directed that the intake for 2028 be doubled—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, it is not done.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, number three, there was no cocoa haircut. He is attempting to indicate that there was a haircut, but there was no haircut. He can steal that slogan into his diction, but it would not work. There was no haircut. Mr Speaker, number four, let me, on a very solemn note, extend our condolences to the family of the two passengers who were on board the private helicopter that crashed a short while ago in Tema. That was what took the Minister for the Interior from this

Floor, and it has become a major issue. We want to extend our condolences to the two people who were on board. It was such a tragic accident.

Mr Speaker, on this note, we will take steps to ensure that the Minister for the Interior comes to brief the House on the recruitment matters and any other related matters that the House is interested in. I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, being fortified by Standing Order 56 (2), I will proceed to adjourn the House.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 6:18 p.m. till Tuesday, 17th March, 2026, at 12:00 noon.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was corrected by the House on 25th March, 2026.

Column 45, paragraph 3, line 4, “Bunkprugu” was replaced with “Bunkpurugu”

Column 62, paragraph 4, line 1, “Minority” was deleted and “Majority” inserted.